

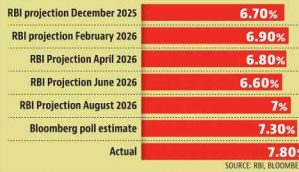


Hindustan Times

India shrugs off oil shock to post 7.8% growth in Q1

How GDP growth estimates moved

Chart shows various RBI MPC projections for April-June 2026 growth and the latest Bloomberg poll estimate, all of which were lower than actual growth



The collective strength of our people ensured India delivered such growth despite global uncertainties. Domsayers were doomed and India bloomed...yet again

NARENDRA MODI, Prime Minister

8 MINORS AMONG 11 DEAD IN BLAST AT ILLEGAL FIRECRACKER UNIT IN KAUSHAMBI

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

PRAYAGRAJ: Eleven people, including eight minors, were killed and more than 200 injured in an explosion at an alleged illegal firecracker factory in Kaushambi district of Uttar Pradesh on Monday, police said, adding a probe has been launched to ascertain the cause of the blast and to determine whether children were working at the factory. →P6

COLLEGIUM PICKS RAJASTHAN HC CHIEF JUSTICE AMID ESCALATING ROW

Utkarsh Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court collegium on Monday evening recommended Chhattisgarh High Court judge Sanjay Kumar Agrawal as the full-time chief justice of the Rajasthan High Court—a move that comes amid an escalating controversy over allegations of “corruption” and “favouritism” against the high court’s acting chief justice Sanjeev Prakash Sharma by Supreme Court Justice Sandeep Mehta. →P2

GOA WON’T TABLE ANTI-CONVERSION BILL IN HOUSE AS MLAS PUSH BACK

Gerard de Souza
letters@hindustantimes.com

PANAJI: The controversial anti-conversion bill will not be tabled during the monsoon session of the Goa assembly, days after the state cabinet cleared it, a BJP lawmaker said, a decision that came after MLAs, including from the BJP, met CM Pramod Sawant and opposed its introduction, he added. →P6

{ 21-YR ARGENTINA CAREER ENDS }

After 207 games, 125 goals and 1 World Cup, Messi bids farewell to international football

Dhiman Sarkar
letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Lionel Messi first announced his retirement from international football in June 2016. He stayed away less than three months. But the possibility of an era ending felt more real on Monday, when the Argentina talisman said he was ending a 21-year senior career for his country after winning one World Cup and two Copa America titles.

Messi, 39, takes his career to the sunset with La Albiceleste after 207 matches, after 125 goals, after the heartbreak of a second World Cup final loss in July, and after the death of his father Jorge in August. He stands shoulder to shoulder



Lionel Messi with the FIFA World Cup trophy in 2022.

der with Diego Maradona, a compatriot with whom he was so often compared, and Brazil icon Pelé as the greatest players of all time.

For many, he’s the best. “It was a decision that hurt, and still hurts deep down, but I understand that the time has come,” Messi said on Instagram.

“Time is running short, chapters come to a close, and this is one that hurts me deeply. I love, have loved, and will always love being part of the national team.” →P8

Roshan Kishore
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Indian economy grew at 7.8% in the first quarter (April-June 2026) of the current fiscal year braving what has been described as the largest oil shock in the history of capitalism. The data, released by the National Statistics Office (NSO) on Monday, positively surprised analysts and pleased the government.

“India’s exemplary GDP growth of 7.8% during Q1 of FY 2026-27 is a herculean feat. The collective strength of our people ensured India delivered such growth despite oil price shocks and supply chain issues in the midst of global uncertainties. Domsayers were doomed and India bloomed...yet again!” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a post on X.

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman also attributed the performance to the government’s reforms and economic management. “The credit for this strong performance goes to the people of India and their hard work. Reforms undertaken by the NDA Government, together with an agile management of the economy, are bearing results,” Sitharaman said on social media.

Experts believe the latest GDP data does not rule out a growth slowdown over the full fiscal year and also increases the possibility of a rate hike later in the year. The latest numbers should not, however, be seen as evidence that the West Asia war did not adversely affect India’s economic momentum. The latest GDP data, which now incorpo-

continued on →7

NEW DELHI REJECTS HAGUE COURT’S RULING ON INDUS

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India on Monday rejected the Permanent Court of Arbitration’s order setting aside its decision to suspend the Indus Waters Treaty with Pakistan, saying it never recognised the existence of the “illegally-constituted” court in The Hague. →P11

BELOW-NORMAL RAINS IN SEPT: IMD AFTER HOTTEST AUG

NEW DELHI: The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday forecast a below normal rainfall (less than 91% of long period average) across the country in September—meaning the monsoon season will certainly end on a deficit now. Data also showed this was the warmest August on record—since 1901, in terms of mean temperature across the country. →P8

APEX COURT DECLINES TO INTERVENE IN CJP’S SEPT 5 PLANNED MARCH

The Supreme Court on Monday declined to interfere with the proposed September 5 protest march in Delhi by the CJP, saying it was for the Centre and Delhi government to take a call on law-and-order arrangements and stressing that all stakeholders were expected to act peacefully. →P10

powers under Article 142 of the Constitution, seeking quashing of the 13 FIRs and permission to register one fresh, specific case limited to the 2,873 persons. The application said the new FIR would be in conformity with the court’s clarification on “criminal antecedents” in its previous order.

The plea is likely to come up continued on →7

Govt defers Census in Manipur amid demand to first hold NRC

Prawesh Lama and Thomas Ngangom
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/IMPHAL: The Union government on Monday deferred the 2027 census in Manipur amid mounting violence and demands by large chunks of the population to update the National Register of Citizens (NRC) before conducting the population enumeration exercise.

The development came a day before house-listing of the census exercise was scheduled to begin in the strife-torn state where 300 have died since May 2023.

The decision came after Union home minister Amit Shah chaired a high-level review meeting in New Delhi to “assess the current situation” in Manipur, according to a statement issued by the chief minister’s office.

“The meeting agreed to defer the proposed census exercise in the state considering the feelings

9 NAGA MLAS, INCLUDING DY CM, WRITE TO SHAH AGAINST KUKI LEADERS

Nine Naga MLAs from Manipur’s ruling coalition have urged Union Home Minister Amit Shah to take immediate action against Kuki-Zo leaders over their alleged role in the killing of Naga civilians. In a letter to Shah, the MLAs, including deputy chief minister Losai Diko, also sought action against fellow Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen, alleging that she colluded with Kuki militant groups. →P5

3 KILLED AFTER FRESH ATTACK, ARSON ROCK KANGPOKPI DISTRICT

At least three people were killed after a group of gunmen attacked a village in the Kangpokpi district of Manipur, officials aware of the matter said on Monday, in the latest instance of violence in the district marked by clashes between Kuki and Naga communities. Monday’s attack came days after four people from the Naga community were killed in an ambush in the district. →P5

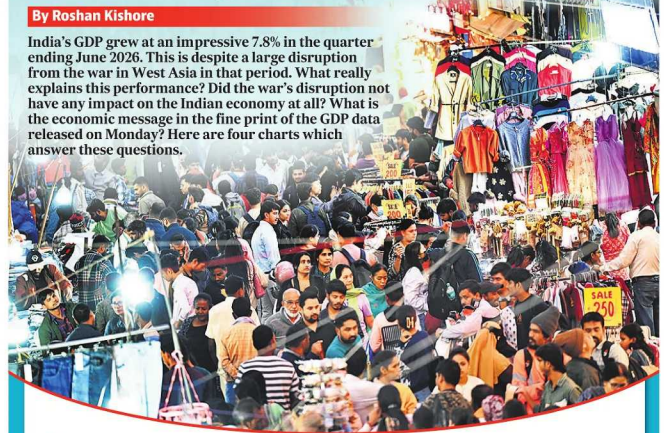
and aspirations of the people of Manipur,” the statement said. The first phase of Census 2027 (house-listing) in Manipur was scheduled from September 1 to September 30. →P5

NUMBER THEORY

Decoding 7.8% GDP growth

By Roshan Kishore

India's GDP grew at an impressive 7.8% in the quarter ending June 2026. This is despite a large disruption from the war in West Asia in that period. What really explains this performance? Did the war's disruption not have any impact on the Indian economy at all? What is the economic message in the fine print of the GDP data released on Monday? Here are four charts which answer these questions.



1 The war did hurt the economy...

When the National Statistics Office (NSO) released GDP data for the quarter ending March 2026 on June 5, growth was estimated to be 7.8%. When read with this number, the latest GDP print of 7.8% shows absolutely no impact of the war. However, the data released on Monday has updated the previous GDP numbers, which "have now incorporated the new series of Output PPI, Index of Industrial Production (IIP) with

base year 2022-23 and updated administrative data from different sources". This has led to the March quarter GDP growth number going to 8.6%. When compared with this, the latest GDP growth shows a slowdown by 80 basis points. One basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point. To be sure, 7.8% is still a very good number and better than what the RBI and private analysts expected.

GDP growth fell after the West Asia war but it is still impressive

Year-on-year growth in percent for quarterly GDP at constant prices

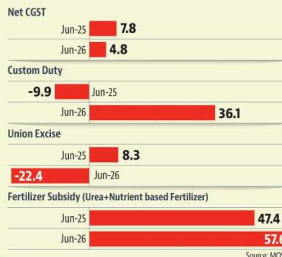


2 ...And its fiscal implications can be seen in fall in excise duty, rise in fertiliser subsidies

The crux of the matter is obvious in the headline GDP and Gross Value Added (GVA) numbers. At 7.8%, GDP growth is lagging the 8.2% growth in GVA in the June quarter. GDP is GVA plus Net Indirect Taxes (NIT), so the latter being ahead of former means a reduction in NIT. This was to be expected, as the government absorbed the fiscal impact of the higher petroleum and fertilizer prices because of the war and did not pass all of it to consumers. Union excise duty (primarily levied on petrol and diesel sales) and fertilizer subsidy spending numbers confirm this. Some of the excise duty loss could also be attributed to lower product sales. The higher expenditure burden and lower taxes follow the existing fiscal squeeze from reduced GST collections due to lower rates.

The West Asia war has extracted a fiscal cost via fall in taxes and rise in subsidies

Year-on-year growth in percent in quarters ending June 2025 and June 2026



3 The tax-cut induced consumption boom has been acting as a buffer to growth

The last budget announced a reduction in income tax rates in India. This was followed by the government announcing a rationalization of Goods and Services Tax (GST) rates which significantly reduced the cost of many goods and services. One-time purchases of many things, including automobiles, etc. followed. The new rates came into effect on 22 September 2025. Quarterly Private Final Consumption Growth (PFCB) shows a discernible spike from the December 2025 quarter onwards, although it is now beginning to tend towards normal. But this spike has helped growth at a time when external headwinds strengthened. Overall growth would be much lower without this cushion.

The domestic consumption buffer to growth

Year-on-year growth in Private Final Consumption Expenditure in percent



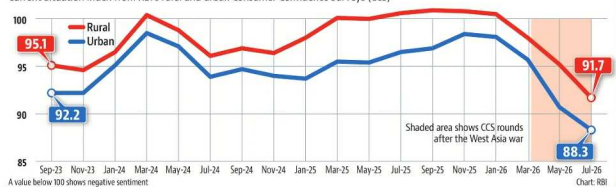
4 Consumer sentiment has fallen further after the June quarter

The latest GDP numbers came a day after the US and Iran fired projectiles at each other after a brief lull in hostilities. An amicable resolution of the war and normal resumption of traffic through the Strait of Hormuz continues to remain elusive. The 2026 monsoon, after a long time, will be deficient and persisting El Nino conditions will weigh on the winter harvest as well. Consumers are not oblivious to these adverse developments and consumer sentiment, as

seen in RBI's rural and urban consumer confidence surveys, shows a falling trend since the outbreak of the war. To be sure, India can do little to influence the geopolitical headwinds to its economy. But it needs to be kept in mind that resilience cannot be an endless substitute for momentum. This is the crux of the Indian economy story right now: Sustaining high growth will take either easing of external headwinds or unlocking new tailwinds.

Consumer sentiment has been weakening since the West Asia war has broken out

Current Situation Index from RBI's rural and urban Consumer Confidence Surveys (CCS)





Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

BRICS SUMMIT

12 - 13 September 2026 New Delhi, India

People-Centric
Approach
Spirit of
Humanity First



CEC: 14/29/13/0011/2627

CONDUCTOR AND DRIVER HELD FOR TEEN'S RAPE IN MOVING NCR BUS

Hemani Bhandari

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The driver and conductor of a sleeper bus were arrested for allegedly gang-raping a 16-year-old girl from Uttar Pradesh after misleading her into boarding the vehicle in Greater Noida, eventually dropping her off near Kashmir Gate, last month, police said on Monday.

According to Delhi Police, the Class II student, who lives in Mainpuri, left home on August 3 without informing her parents after being reprimanded by her mother over her studies. She wanted to travel to her cousin's home in Sector 63, Noida, deputy commissioner of police (north) Niharika Bhatt said.

The girl told police that she accidentally got off at Pari Chowk after dark. She then saw a bus approaching and signalled for it to stop, an officer familiar with the investigation said.

The two men allegedly threatened to kill her when she resisted, police said.

moreonline

Maupur playschool where kid was beaten sealed

Driver held for sexually assaulting girl at school

PM urges Putin to end 'endless war'

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Russia should move from 'endless war towards the end of war', Prime Minister Narendra Modi told President Vladimir Putin on Monday, nudging the Russian leader yet again to end the more than four-year-old conflict that has had an adverse impact on the global community.

Modi made the remarks when he met Putin on the margins of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in the Kyrgyz capital of Bishkek, their first in-person engagement since the annual India-Russia Summit in New Delhi last December. India hasn't publicly criticised Russia's invasion of Ukraine but has backed dialogue and diplomacy to find a resolution.

The two leaders met against the backdrop of increased tensions over Russian and Ukrainian attacks on merchant vessels in the Black Sea that have killed at least five Indian seafarers. The impact of the attacks in the Black Sea on maritime trade and the safety of Indian seafarers figured

continued on P7



PM Narendra Modi and Russian President Vladimir Putin travel together in Putin's limousine to the venue of the inaugural ceremony of the World Nomad Games on Monday.

Modi, Pezeshkian meet, focus on W Asia conflict

Rezaul H Laskar

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India is concerned by the escalation of tensions in West Asia and supports all efforts aimed at lasting peace in the region, PM Narendra Modi told Iranian Presi-

dent Masoud Pezeshkian on Monday, while simultaneously calling for freedom of navigation and protection of civilians and civil infrastructure. Modi and Pezeshkian met for the first time since the start of the Iran-US conflict on the margins of SCO summit.

U.S., IRAN TRADE STRIKES AFTER A MONTH; TRUMP VOWS BIGGER HIT

DUBAI/ASHEVILLE: US President Donald Trump on Monday promised further strikes against Iran after the first tit-for-tat attacks in a month, as a conflict that had lately settled into an economic standoff threatened to escalate into open fighting again. Iran launched missiles overnight at two US air bases in Jordan in response to a U.S. attack on Iran's Larak Island, where Washington said it had struck Iranian launchers firing missiles into the Strait of Hormuz.

IN Q1, INDIA'S LPG IMPORTS FROM U.S. SURGED, OIL PURCHASES FELL

Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's imports of petroleum products from the U.S. mainly LPG, surged 254% year-on-year to \$2.60 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27, even as crude oil imports from the country fell 57.5% to \$1.57 billion during the same period, according to government data. The rise in April-June was partly driven by global energy supply disruptions linked to the war in West Asia.

Nepal deaths approach 1k

955 Dead
4,400 Missing

Over 600 working at 11 hydropower sites still missing. 19-member team from India begins DNA testing in Nepal.

A wrecked building along Trishuli River in Nepal. AFP

Gap between men, women narrows in Delhi draft roll

Saloni Bhatia and Abhishek Jha

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Monday published the draft electoral roll for Delhi, dropping nearly 4.76 million or 32.8% names - marking the deletion of more male names than women and the highest proportion of removal at the draft stage among 30 states and Union territories where the controversial exercise was conducted.

Men accounted for 57.2% of the deletions and women 42.8%, according to ECI data. In the

draft roll, the ratio of men to women stands at 51.15% to 48.85%, compared to 53.15% to 46.85% before SIR. The change will have implications for the city-state's polity and policies, especially initiatives such as cash transfers for women.

Among the six metro cities - Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata, Chennai, Bengaluru, and Hyderabad - Delhi's 32.8% deletions at the draft stage are the second lowest. In other cities, the deletions were 42.5% in Bengaluru, 4% in Hyderabad, 35.6% in Chennai, 34.8% in Mumbai, and 25.1% in Kolkata.

NCLT FORMS BIGGER BENCH TO DECIDE SUBHASH CHANDRA REPAYMENT PLAN

Krishna Yadav

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Hours after an appeals court agreed to hear aggrieved lenders in the Subhash Chandra case, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) formed a new five-member special bench to reconsider the Zee Group's founder's \$6.5 crore repayment plan it approved last week. The Delhi bench of NCLT said its previous three-member bench which approved the plan could not agree on how it would operate.



continued on P2

A GOOD CHOICE IS NOT HAVING TO CHOOSE

Why pick one?

- ☒ No Maida
- ☒ High Fibre
- ☒ Great Taste

TURN TO PAGE 3

13 FROM K'TAKA
REMAIN MISSING
IN NEPAL AFTER
FLASH FLOODS: CM

Arun Dev
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: About 13 people from Karnataka remained unaccounted for after last week's floods near the Nepal-Tibet border, chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Monday.

The state emergency operation centre had on Friday said 28 people from Karnataka were caught in the disaster in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region. Four had been confirmed safe at that point, leaving 24 whose whereabouts were being established. Shivakumar's latest estimate puts the number still untraced at roughly 13.

"Around 13 people are yet to be traced. Our officials are in touch with the ministry of external affairs (MEA) and the central government. We have sent our representatives to establish contact. One group could not be traced; all the others have been traced," he said.

Around 23 of the 28 people identified by the state were from Bengaluru city district. Most of those believed to be missing or stranded were reported to be in Timur in Rasuva district of Nepal, while some were in Darchen in the Tibet Autonomous Region.

He said he had spoken to some of the people stranded in the affected areas.

CID detains B. leader in KPSC recruitment probe

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The Karnataka criminal investigation department (CID) has detained Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Basavara Kannale in Delhi in connection with alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) recruitment of 400 veterinary officers, and is questioning his suspected links with IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, who was taken into custody in the same case, officials said on Monday.

Kannale, a BJP functionary from Bidar, is being brought to Bengaluru and is expected to be produced before a court late on Monday. The CID is likely to seek his custody for further questioning.

Investigators suspect Kannale may have been involved in a network in which middlemen allegedly demanded ₹80 lakh for each veterinary officer post, with ₹40 lakh sought as an advance. The money was allegedly sought to manipulate OMR answer sheets and leak question papers to increase candidates' marks.

SENIOR CID OFFICIALS SAID KANNALE WAS IN REGULAR CONTACT WITH GANGWAR, WHO SERVED AS KPSC CONTROLLER OF EXAMINATIONS FROM 2024 UNTIL MARCH 2026

Kannale is a syndicate member of Tumakuru University and has business interests including the travel sector. He owns buses and cabs, according to officials. The CID suspects he may have played a role in the alleged irregularities.

Senior CID officials said Kannale was in regular contact with Gangwar, who served as KPSC controller of examinations from 2024 until March 2026 and is now director of MSME in the industries department.

Gangwar was taken into custody on Saturday after several other officials said he had not cooperated with investigators. His role is being examined in connection with the examination conducted while he was serving as controller of examinations.

The recruitment examination was held on January 8 and 400 posts in the animal husbandry and fisheries department.

The KPSC published the final selection list on July 17.

The CID has already arrested two alleged middlemen, Sikanar Chaudhary and Arif Mulla. Investigators have seized 658 OMR sheets to the forensic science laboratory for examination, while the enforcement directorate is examining financial transactions linked to the case.

The investigation began at Vidhana Soudha police station after complaints were filed by the department and an aspirant identified as Manjunath.

The director general of police later transferred the case to the CID.

His detention has also raised questions within the BJP after party leaders at BJP events were circulated. Officials of the Opposition R Ashok said the photographs did not establish any connection to the alleged scam. "We are clear that whoever they are, if they are found to be part of the scam, should be punished. As for the photos, many people take photos with it. It doesn't prove anything," he said.

The investigation is examining the alleged role of middlemen, the handling of OMR sheets and question papers, and financial transactions associated with the recruitment process.

BJP leader B Vijayendra Karandlaje has called for a CBI inquiry into the case, saying it was necessary to ensure transparency and accountability and restore public confidence in the recruitment system.

Gangwar had also recently remained uncommunicated for two days beginning August 20 before later contacting the government.

The CID is now questioning Kannale as investigators seek to establish his role in the alleged irregularities and determine whether the suspected payment demands and examination were circulated. Officials connected to the recruitment process.

beloved bangalore

An English noblewoman on the Tiger's trail



Roopa Pai

On September 3, 1758, 268 years ago this week, a girl child was born into a titled family of Shropshire, the English county that borders Wales. That child, mineral collector and botanist Henrietta Herbert, would grow up to have a very close connection with Mysore, Seringapatam and Bangalore; her extensive journals, written between 1798 and 1801, are among the first written accounts of India by a British woman.

What's more, a large chunk of her journal entries record a 1,000-mile journey—part scientific expedition, part diplomatic mission—that she undertook across south India in her one-horse *bundy*, accompanied by her daughters Henrietta (Henry), 13, and Charlotte (Charly) 12; her governess, the Italian portraitist, Anna Tonelli; 14 elephants, 100 bullocks, two camels, palanquins, a harp, a pianoforte, and a retinue of 750 servants. But Henrietta's connection to India was forged well before she was born.

In 1758, former Governor of Bengal Robert Clive returned to England and renamed his estate in Ireland, calling it Plassey, the name of the place where we gained our great victory in India to which I owe all my good fortune. In 1762, as 1st Baron Clive of Plassey, he returned to India for another stint in Bengal. When he went home for good in 1767, the lost from his military career had made Clive one of the richest men in Europe. In 1771, he bought Henrietta's childhood home, Oakley Park.

Henrietta's teenage years were therefore spent in Powis Castle, the Herberts' ancestral home in Wales. In 1784, the Herbert and Clive families came together in a mutually beneficial alliance when Henrietta married Edward Clive, the eldest son of the 1st Baron Clive—Edward gained the

superior title of Earl of Powis, while the Herbert family was able to repay its very considerable debts. Appointed Governor of Madras in 1788, Edward arrived with his family to take charge of Fort St George, where, in 1744, his father had begun his India innings as a lowly clerk in the East India Company (EIC). For an aristocratic woman, Henrietta had unusual hobbies. It isn't clear when her interest in collecting, studying and cataloguing rocks and minerals began, but India proved to be a treasure-trove. At first, with the Fourth Anglo-Mysore War between Tipu Sultan and the EIC raging, she was restricted to humid Madras, where she spent her time learning Farsi and Hindustani. But once Tipu fell on May 4, 1799, the peninsula, and especially the cool, lush Mysore plateau, lay open to her explorations. Leaving her husband to his official duties, she set off with her crew on March 4, 1800.

Over the next seven months, Lady Clive travelled through Vellore, Bangalore, Mysore, Coimbatore, Trichinopoly, Tanjore, Tranquebar and Pondicherry, adding to her rock collection and making extensive notes on the landscape, plants, minerals, wildlife, art and culture. What, of course, was an object of fascination—Henrietta reports blood stains, still unfaded, on the walls of the Water Gate in Seringapatam where Tipu lived, remarking, "it is a very extraordinary event certainly, that five months ago... the army passed the frontiers of Tipu's country... [now]... he is dead, his country divided... and the English position secure forever."

On her part, Anna Tonelli turned out great numbers of sketches, but her most exceptional one remains *Tipu Sultan Enthroned*, a portrait of Tipu on his octagonal Tiger Throne with his eight jewel-encrusted gold tiger head finials. Henrietta's precocious daughter Charly, who would go on to become the governor of Madras, was also a keen collector. She also mentions the throne in her journal; her entry for May 10th, 1799, records the death of Tipu six days earlier, and adds, awe-struck: "His throne is said to be worth £100,000, which is more than English money is £120,000."

When the throne was dismantled, one of the gorgeously worked tiger head finials was gifted to Lady Clive. It is now part of the Clive Museum collection displayed at Powis Castle.

(Roopa Pai is a writer who has carried on a longtime love affair with her hometown Bengaluru)

Patients forced to clean hospital sewage, 2 booked

Yohan P Hanadri
letters@hindustantimes.com

BIDAR: A case has been registered against two officials at Savanur Taluk Health Centre, Haveri district after two patients were allegedly made to remove human waste from an overflowing sewage pit on the hospital premises, police said on Monday.

The alleged incident took place on August 28 and was recorded by local residents, with videos later circulating on social media. The footage showed two patients carrying human waste in buckets after opening the cover of a sewage pit at the hospital.

The FIR, registered at Savanur police station, names administrative officer Dr Shankar Hiregowda and senior nursing officer Vanitha, police said, adding that the charges include Section 125 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and Sections 5, 7, 8 and 9 of the Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers and their Rehabilitation Act, 2013.

The complaint to register the two men, from Hulugar village in Shiggaon taluk, had come to the hospital for medical treatment. They had contacted



The alleged incident took place on August 28.

Vanitha, a nursing supervisor at the hospital, through an acquaintance and arrived on August 28.

It is alleged that Vanitha directed them to inspect a toilet where water had accumulated and determine the cause. The medical officer is also alleged to have asked them to clean the sewage pit, telling them they would receive better treatment if they did the work.

The men are alleged to have opened the pit after freezing the toilet and found it filled with sewage. Using buckets supplied by the hospital, they began removing the human waste and carrying it outside.

The activity was noticed by residents after a foul smell from the premises reached nearby houses. Residents

entered the hospital compound and found the two men engaged in the work. When questioned, the men said they were patients who had come for treatment.

Residents then asked them to stop and confronted hospital staff. After an initial evasive response and growing public anger, a municipal vehicle was brought in and the sewage pit was cleaned mechanically.

Haveri district health and family welfare officer Dr Nagaraj said the sewage pit had been overflowing and that the hospital administration had sought help from the municipal authorities before the incident.

"The sewage pit on the hospital premises was overflowing. Administrative officer Dr Shankar Hiregowda had written a request to the municipal authorities on August 27, requesting them to clean it, but there was no response," Dr Nagaraj told HT. The said action had already been initiated against two officers.

"A suspension order was served against two officers, and an investigation is being conducted. Serious action will be taken if they are found guilty after the investigation," the DHO said.

Food safety dept raids 16 sweet units, seizes products worth ₹5.9L

Arun Dev
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Food safety officials raided 16 sweet units worth ₹5.99 lakh after inspecting 16 sweet manufacturing units across Karnataka on Monday, finding expired curd, improperly labelled chocolate, lemonade material and about 60 kg of misbranded food products, the food safety and drug administration department said.

The operation covered sweet units in Bengaluru Urban, Bengaluru rural, the Greater Bengaluru Authority, Mysuru City Corporation, Dakshina Kannada, Belagavi, Kalaburgi and Hubballi Dharwad Municipal Corporation areas.

The department said the inspections were intended to enforce food safety and hygiene requirements and identify violations of the law. "The special drive was undertaken to ensure strict compliance with food safety, hygiene and quality standards and to safeguard public health," the food safety and drug administration department said.

"The department also initiated action against establishments where violations of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, and the rules and regulations framed thereunder were identified." Among the products seized were 5 litres of expired Nanuani curd, 13 large packets and 6 small packets of chocolate decoration products that had improper

THE DEPARTMENT SAID ABOUT 60 KG OF PRODUCTS, INCLUDING BANANA CHIPS AND CHAKLI MASALA, DID NOT MEET MANDATORY LABELLING NEEDS

labelling, 10 kg of chocolate flavour and 5 kg of rasgulla. Officials also seized 367 kg of ready to eat savouries, 196 kg of fennel powder, 6 kg of khova, 4.5 kg of cracked cocoa beans and 4 kg of cocoa powder.

The department said about 60 kg of products, including banana chips and chakli masala, did not meet mandatory labelling requirements.

"Approximately 60 kg of various food products, including Banana Chips and Chakli Masala, were found to be misbranded," the department said. "The products did not carry mandatory labelling information, including the manufacturer's name and address and FSSAI licence number." Officials collected samples for laboratory examination. The material sent for testing included sweets, cooking oil, fresh oil, curd, pulses, chickpeas, jalebi, khova and tea products. The laboratory results will determine if the sampled products comply with the requirements.

Coovercolly Indresh
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: About 31 Bangladeshi nationals detained in Bengaluru have been moved to Malda in West Bengal, where authorities will complete the formalities required before handing them over to border officials for deportation to Bangladesh, officials said on Monday.

The group was taken from Sir M Veeravarma Terminal railway station on Sunday night in a special coach arranged for the transfer.

Twenty police personnel are accompanying them and are expected to reach Malda on Tuesday evening, Electronic City

deputy commissioner of police M Narayan said.

"31 Bangladeshi nationals have been sent to Malda from SMVT railway station for further deportation proceedings. A team of 20 police personnel has been deployed as an escort."

The transfer follows the required legal procedures in Malda, they will be handed over through the appropriate border authorities," Narayan said.

The transfer follows directions from the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), which received details and police reports on Bangladeshi nationals identified during a verification drive in Bengaluru.

"The police began 'Operation

Mukhta' on August 9, focusing on the Whitefield and Electronic City police divisions to identify foreign nationals suspected of living in the city without valid documentation or authorisation. Police teams checked the documents of 2944 people during the operation, identifying 105 Bangladeshi nationals who were allegedly staying illegally."

Electronic City accounted for 43 of those cases. Twenty-three persons residing in the city were identified. Documents of 1,909 people in the division before compiling reports and forwarding the details to the FRRO. Following their orders, proceedings have now begun against 31 of the identified individuals.

Police teams checked the documents of 2944 people during the operation, identifying 105 Bangladeshi nationals who were allegedly staying illegally."

NGT directs pollution board to track Udupi fish processing unit

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The National Green Tribunal's Southern Zone Bench has directed the Karnataka State Pollution Control Board (KSPCB) to continue monitoring a fish-processing unit in Udupi district, including regular sampling and analysis of effluents and the surrounding air quality, and ordered strict compliance with environmental safeguards.

A Bench of Justice Pushpa Sathyanarayana and Expert Member Dr Prashant Gargava directed the unit to ensure continuous operation and maintenance of its Effluent Treatment Plant (ETP), maintain complete records relating to the generation and disposal of trade effluents and fish waste, and dispose of solid waste only through authorised agencies in accordance with the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026.

The Tribunal further directed the board to ensure the unit to verify that groundwater extraction by the unit remains within the limits permitted under its licence. In case of any unauthorised extraction, appropriate action shall be initiated in accordance with law. The Bench also clarified that if any future inspection reveals the violation of standard conditions, the authorities would be at liberty to initiate

THE TRIBUNAL ORDERED THE GROUNDWATER AUTHORITY TO VERIFY THAT ITS EXTRACTION BY THE UNIT REMAINS WITHIN THE LIMITS PERMITTED

appropriate proceedings. The directions came while disposing of an application filed by an environmental protection association from Udupi district, which had alleged pollution from the fish-processing activity and discharge of untreated industrial effluents into the Panashini River.

The applicant had contended that the unit was initially permitted only for freezing activity under the Green Category but subsequently undertook Surimi fish processing, which involved increased water consumption and generation of trade effluents, fish waste and odour.

The Tribunal, however, noted that the unit had subsequently applied for expansion, increasing its production capacity from 350 tonnes per month to 550 tonnes per month and modifying its manufacturing process to conduct processing of whole fish.

GOVT TO EXPEDITE INSTALLATION OF ROOFTOP SOLARS ON BUILDINGS

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The state government will accelerate rooftop solar installations on government buildings under the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, officials said on Monday.

Additional Chief Secretary, Energy Department, Gaurav Gupta, reviewed the progress of solarising government buildings and the scheme's symposium mechanism at a meeting with senior officials at the BESCOM Corporate Office here, officials said.

According to Gupta, the Public Works Department will survey government buildings, while the Karnataka Renewable Energy Development Limited will implement rooftop solar projects through the public-private partnership model.

"Priority will be given to promoting the use of renewable energy in government buildings," Gupta said at the meeting with senior officials at the BESCOM Corporate Office here, officials said.

Explaining the Renewable Energy Service Company and capital expenditure models, Gupta said government departments would have to make any upfront investment under the ESCO model, as developers would bear the entire project cost.

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The BJP will begin a 10-day padayatra from Gurugram to Bengaluru on Tuesday to protest the alleged failures of the Congress government, leaders in the know said on Monday. However, the 170 km march to Ballari will proceed without the participation of its NDA ally, the Janata Dal (Secular), revealing fresh differences between the two parties in Karnataka.

The BJP has decided to proceed with the march even after former minister B Nagendra resigned, remarking the immediate issue around which the march had mounted pressure on the Congress government. BJP state president BV Vijayendra has said the campaign will instead cover a broader range of issues.

"The resignation of Nagendra was also one of the issues included in our padayatra. Apart from Linguswami and Ballari will proceed without the participation of its NDA ally, the Janata Dal (Secular), revealing fresh differences between the two parties in Karnataka."

The BJP has decided to proceed with the march even after former minister B Nagendra resigned, remarking the immediate issue around which the march had mounted pressure on the Congress government. BJP state president BV Vijayendra has said the campaign will instead cover a broader range of issues.

BJP to launch 10 day padayatra against Cong from Gurugram to Ballari today



BV Vijayendra

There is a drought issue. Around 2.5 lakh vacancies are still unfilled."

The JD(S), however, said it was not consulted before the BJP fixed the dates. Party leaders said the march was being treated as a BJP programme rather than an alliance event. Union minister for industries and steel HD Kumaraswamy said he had not been consulted about the decision and questioned the purpose of the march after Nagendra's resignation.

"I was not consulted on the issue. I do not know the subject for which they are taking out the padayatra. We were together in the Legislative Assembly, over Nagendra's issue. Our workers are free to go

If they want to," Kumaraswamy said. Kumaraswamy will be in the United States for an event and return on September 12.

JD(S) youth wing president Nihal Kumaraswamy also travelled to the United States with his family around the same time. Before Nagendra resigned, Kumaraswamy had asked JD(S) colleagues to oblige by not supporting the BJP campaign.

He said he was not unsure what the next step should be. "I do not know the next step after Nagendra has resigned," he said. Kumaraswamy has conveyed his inability to attend the march to Leader of Opposition R Ashoka and Vijayendra, while extending his support, according to party insiders.

Vijayendra had earlier said the JD(S) would participate in the opening and closing programmes and that Kumaraswamy had supported the march after the two spoke. Following Kumaraswamy's remarks, Vijayendra said he would speak to him again.

The dispute is part of a wider pattern of differences between the allies. The two parties have been at odds over Nagendra's issue. Our workers are free to go

Bengaluru Integrated Township in Ballari. When Nihal Kumaraswamy led a JD(S) mobilisation against the project at Byramangala on August 10 and BJP minister B Nagendra were absent, most BJP leaders and supporters dominated the gathering. Days later, Vijayendra had said he would lead a campaign with minister Madhu Bangarappa during a drought review. Vijayendra said the BJP was extending only symbolic support and that several farmers had accepted compensation.

He later defended the remark, saying farmers were being forced to accept compensation. The parties had also been at odds over the BJP's earlier padayatra from Bengaluru to Mysuru over the MUDA issue. The JD(S) initially expressed reservations about the joint action during consultations with senior BJP leaders. Deputy CM G Parameshwara said the BJP had the right to hold its march but should not throw dust into people's eyes," he said.

He said building more roads alone would not resolve the city's traffic crisis, as vehicles were routinely parked on both sides of even narrow roads, the existing civic and police workforce was inadequate for the task. "Unless people develop a sense of self-discipline, it will be impossible to solve the problem of Bengaluru's traffic problem," Gowda said at a meeting with former mayors at Vidhana Soudha here.

He said building more roads alone would not resolve the city's traffic crisis, as vehicles were routinely parked on both sides of even narrow roads, the existing civic and police workforce was inadequate for the task. "Unless people develop a sense of self-discipline, it will be impossible to solve the problem of Bengaluru's traffic problem," Gowda said at a meeting with former mayors at Vidhana Soudha here.

60% OF ROAD IS OCCUPIED BY PARKED VEHICLES IN B'LRU: MIN

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Around 60 per cent of Bengaluru's road space is occupied by parked vehicles, worsening the city's congestion, Karnataka Minister Krishna Byre Gowda said on Monday.

Calling for urgent action, the Government Minister and Union minister said the government should consider appointing a dedicated agency to regulate and enforce parking rules, as the existing civic and police workforce was inadequate for the task. "Unless people develop a sense of self-discipline, it will be impossible to solve the problem of Bengaluru's traffic problem," Gowda said at a meeting with former mayors at Vidhana Soudha here.

He said building more roads alone would not resolve the city's traffic crisis, as vehicles were routinely parked on both sides of even narrow roads, the existing civic and police workforce was inadequate for the task. "Unless people develop a sense of self-discipline, it will be impossible to solve the problem of Bengaluru's traffic problem," Gowda said at a meeting with former mayors at Vidhana Soudha here.

Tam Nadu Congress leaders meet Vijay over 2:29 PM candidate row

S Vijay Karthik
 letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: The top brass of the Tamil Nadu Congress, including state president B Manickam Tagore and MP Praveen Chakravarthy, met chief minister C Joseph Vijay at the Secretariat in Chennai on Monday over the ongoing prime ministerial candidate row in the state.

The meeting assumes significance amid a row in the southern state following remarks by Congress minister S Rajesh Kumar that he and his colleague P Viswanathan would resign as members if the ruling Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) did not support Congress leader Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate for the 2029 elections. The Congress, which won five seats under the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance, snapped ties with the DMK and formed an alliance with TVK after the April 23 Assembly election results were announced on May 4. The alliance requires 118 numbers to form the government.

After a gap of 59 years, the



C Joseph Vijay and B Manickam Tagore

Congress has two representatives in the cabinet led by chief minister C Joseph Vijay. Rajesh Kumar is the tourism minister and MLA from Kolluvur constituency in Kanniyakumari, while Viswanathan is the higher education minister and MLA from Melur constituency in Madurai district.

Trouble began in the TVK-Progressive Alliance, snapped ties with the DMK and formed an alliance with TVK after the April 23 Assembly election results were announced on May 4. The alliance requires 118 numbers to form the government.

At an event in Madurai, social welfare and women empowerment minister K Jagadeeshwari



C Joseph Vijay and B Manickam Tagore

said, "our CM will be the next PM" amid thunderous support from the audience. Similarly, human resource and management minister D Sarath Kumar, while speaking in the Assembly last week, said, "our leader (C Joseph Vijay) who is in our hearts and as the chief minister in the Fort (Fort St George, the Secretariat) you are our tomorrow's Prime Minister for Bharat".

The Congress has maintained that Rahul Gandhi would be its prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?" What the Congress leadership says is right", Elangovan said.

Former minister and senior Congress leader S Thirunavukarasu, however, claimed there was no dispute between TVK and Congress over the issue. "It is only love between them. There is no dispute. He only claimed that he will tender resignation. He did not do so now", he said.

Gandhi had attended Vijay's swearing-in ceremony along with nine of his ministers on May 10, soon after TVK emerged victorious in the Assembly polls.

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

On August 29 in Kanniyaku-

date? What the Congress leadership says is right", Elangovan said.

Former minister and senior Congress leader S Thirunavukarasu, however, claimed there was no dispute between TVK and Congress over the issue. "It is only love between them. There is no dispute. He only claimed that he will tender resignation. He did not do so now", he said.

Gandhi had attended Vijay's swearing-in ceremony along with nine of his ministers on May 10, soon after TVK emerged victorious in the Assembly polls.

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

mar, Rajesh Kumar said, "If Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam does not accept our demand, the two Congress ministers will not continue in the ministry". He stressed that political parties may have different opinions, but Rahul Gandhi would be the only prime ministerial candidate for the Congress.

On Monday, Tagore and Chakravarthy called on Vijay at the Secretariat. The meeting lasted around 20 minutes, people aware of the matter said. However, what was discussed between the leaders was not known.

Meanwhile, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), the Congress's erstwhile partner, backed its demand to project Rahul Gandhi as the prime ministerial candidate. DMK leader and spokesperson TKS Elangovan said the Congress stance was right and questioned TVK's rationale for positioning Vijay for the top post. "Congress is a major political party in the country and has ruled the nation for years. How can TVK want to project Vijay as the Prime Ministerial candidate?"

Besides the Congress, TVK has the support of Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) and Indian Union Muslim League, which won two Assembly seats each and also have ministerial representation in the cabinet. The two left parties, Communist Party of India and CPI (Marxist), which won two seats, offer outside support to the TVK government. HT has reached out to the TVK seeking their views on the matter but did not receive any response.

Cleric's remark on women spark row in Keralam

Vishnu Varma
 letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A prominent Muslim cleric in Keralam has drawn criticism after exhorting women to remain confined to their homes and claiming that their entry into the public sphere would "lead to destruction".

The controversial remarks were made on Sunday by 95-year-old Kathanapuram Aboobacker Musayyar, general secretary of the Aflakun of the Samastha Kerala, Jen-iyathul Ulama, a prominent body of Sunni Muslim clerics in the state, at an Islamic conference in Kochi. "If women enter the public sphere, it will lead to destruction. To avoid this, Islam instructed the concept of 'purdah'. The holy Quran states that women must remain confined inside their homes and avoid coming out in public. It was the right decision," Musayyar was quoted as saying at the conference.

Samastha has been studying Islam for over 100 years, and that's why we have the right to say this to the Muslim community. We will continue to say it. We are not the kind of people who get afraid and run away," he claimed.

The remarks came days after the AP faction of Samastha issued a circular seeking to restrict Muslim women's participation in public events. The circular stated that "displaying young women among unrelated men on roads and public spaces is not appropriate for believers



Kathanapuram AP Aboobacker

and is not permissible."

It asked mosques, madrasas and mahals committees to ensure Islamic celebrations do not cross the limits of religion. The circular followed several Mide-Sharif events organised by youth clubs outside the purview of mosques and mahals committees, where women actively participated alongside men.

Keralam Women and Child Welfare Minister Bindhu Krishna on Monday said, "While the Constitution allows everyone to express their opinions freely, such a stand (of Musayyar) is not fit to propagate in Kerala, India or the rest of the world. Women in our society have equal rights under the Constitution. We are a country that upholds gender equality." "Kishanur, a prominent Congress leader and home minister Ramesh Chennithala said he did not support restricting women in public spaces. "He (Kathanapuram) can say what he wants. But I do not conform to the idea of restricting women in the public sphere," he said.

Indian Union Muslim League leader and Keralam Local Self-Government Minister KM Shaji, however, declined to comment on the remarks.

AIMM WORKER STABBED TO DEATH IN HYDERABAD

Press Trust of India
 letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: An AIMM worker was stabbed to death by a gang near his residence in Hyderabad, police said on Monday. The incident took place on Sunday night at Vattapally.

Mahboob Ali (in his mid-50s) was attacked with knives by a group of five people, who were engaged by a relative of the deceased, a police official said based on preliminary investigation. Ali, who suffered severe bleeding injuries, was shifted to a hospital where he died undergoing treatment.

The exact motive was under investigation, the official said. The police team has apprehended the accused who fled the scene after the murder.

AIMM MLA Mohammed Mubeen visited Ali's residence during the bereavement and members offered condolences.

"Deeply saddened and shocked by the brutal murder of Mahboob Ali Sahab, AIMM Worker, who was attacked by unidentified assailants with deadly weapons at Vattapally," Mohammed Mubeen said in a post on X.

Later, the MLA visited Fakhra Police Station and urged officials to take strict and immediate action against those responsible for the crime and ensure that the culprits are brought to justice.

"We urge the Government of Telangana and Hyderabad Police to strengthen patrolling, crack down on anti-social elements, and take stringent action against the growing menace of drugs and violent crime, so that the safety and security of every citizen is ensured," Mubeen said.

Man arrested for rape-murder of nurse in Telangana: Police

Press Trust of India
 letters@hindustantimes.com

HYDERABAD: A 34-year-old bike mechanic from Bihar was arrested for allegedly raping and murdering a nurse in Hyderabad, police said on Monday.

The woman, who belonged to an ST community and worked as a nurse at a hospital in the Thukuguda area, was found dead on August 29 in a residential room on the hospital premises.

Based on a complaint lodged by the deceased woman's aunt, police registered a case under relevant sections of the BNS and the SCST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. Acting on technical evidence and information gathered during the investigation, police apprehended the accused on Saturday evening. DCP (Shamshad Zone) B Rajesh told reporters.

The accused, a native of Begusarai district in Bihar, worked as a bike mechanic and was staying at the mechanic shop in Thukuguda, adjacent to the crime scene. "After apprehension and questioning him, he confessed to committing the crime of rape and murder," the senior police official said.

The DCP said the accused was

THE ACCUSED, A BIHAR RESIDENT, WORKED AS A BIKE MECHANIC AND WAS STAYING ADJACENT TO THE CRIME SCENE

habituated to consuming alcohol and watching pornographic videos and photographs on his mobile phone.

About a month before the incident, the accused allegedly noticed the woman through a rear-side window of the mechanic shop, developed a sexual interest in her and began observing her movements, he said.

After learning that she worked as a nurse at the hospital and lived in its residential quarters, he allegedly hatched a plan to sexually assault her. During the intervening night of August 28 and 29, he entered her room through a window, police said. "When the woman woke up and raised an alarm, he allegedly covered her mouth with his left hand and held her throat with his right hand."

"During the struggle, she bit

his left little finger and scratched his throat and the left side of his chest. Enraged, he allegedly pushed her down and strangled her, rendering her unable to resist, and thereafter sexually assaulted her. After committing the offence, he closed the window and fled the scene," the DCP said.

The investigation is continuing to collect and analyse scientific, technical and other corroborative evidence in accordance with law, he said.

Police said they suspect the accused sexually assaulted the woman after she fell unconscious. The medical report is awaited, they added.

A friend of the deceased, who also worked as a nurse at the hospital, lodged the complaint by phone on August 29 that the woman had not come out of her room since morning and was not responding despite repeated knocks, police said. The friend and the complainant entered the room through a window and found the woman lying dead with bleeding injuries on her face. The complainant suspected that an unidentified person had assaulted and killed her with an unknown object, police said.

85 untraceable from TN after Nepal floods, state steps up efforts

S Vijay Karthik
 letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: As many as 85 people from Tamil Nadu who undertook the Kaish Mansarovar pilgrimage remain "untraceable" or "missing", and the state government is taking all possible measures in coordination with the Centre, Nepal and the Indian Embassy to bring them back safely, minister Aadhav Arjuna said in the Assembly on Monday.

In a detailed statement, the public works and sports development minister said 305 people from Tamil Nadu had undertaken the pilgrimage. Of these, 220 have been brought back safely, while 85 remained "untraceable".

Recalling the measures taken after the incident on August 20 to bring back Tamil students in Nepal, Arjuna said the government formed a committee of ministers and senior officials, who were deputed to Nepal to coordinate the rescue efforts.

Besides Arjuna, the four-member ministerial team led by chief minister C Joseph Vijay included school education minister Rajmohan, agriculture minister R Vinodh and minister for non-resident Tamil welfare K Thennarasu. While Arjuna and two other ministers returned to Chennai, Thennarasu remains in Delhi to monitor the rescue efforts.

Three officials from Tamil Nadu House in Delhi are also stationed in Kathmandu to assist, he said. Control rooms at the Tamil Nadu Resident Welfare Department in Chennai



Aadhav Arjuna

and Tamil Nadu House in New Delhi are operational 24 hours a day.

"So far, 2,161 phone calls have been received. The information received is being logged immediately, shared with relevant authorities, and necessary rescue protocols are being executed," he said.

Arjuna said the ministerial team met External Affairs ministry officials in Delhi. "When we went to the War Room established by the External Affairs ministry, we gathered updates directly from the Central Command system."

"They informed us that communication needs to be established not just with Nepal but also with the Tibet and the Government of China. The central government is actively maintaining contact with all the three government and handling this appropriately," he said.

Arjuna said the Centre and Tamil Nadu government were tracking developments hourly. "Our prayer is that all 85 missing people return safely to Tamil Nadu, and both the Chief Minister and the state government are working towards this," he added.

CM Naidu launches Phase-I of Velgonda irrigation project

Press Trust of India
 letters@hindustantimes.com

DORNALA (ANDHRA PRADESH): Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday inaugurated Phase-I of the Velgonda irrigation project, releasing Krishna water into Nallamala Sagar.

The project aims to transform drought-prone areas of Markapuram, Prakasam, Nellore and Kadapa districts, which face inadequate rainfall, depleted groundwater, fluoride contamination and irrigation water shortages.

Krishna river waters will be diverted from the Srisailem reservoir through gravity, stored in Nallamala Sagar and supplied through main canals for irrigation and drinking-water requirements.

With Phase-1, 10,70 TMC of Krishna water will enter Nallamala Sagar, providing irrigation to 119 lakh acres and drinking water to four lakh people. Once fully operational, Velgonda will irrigate 4.47 lakh acres across 30 mandals and provide drinking water benefits to around 23 lakh people, including fluoride-affected areas.

The NDA coalition government has spent more than Rs 2,400 crore on Velgonda in two



AP CM N Chandrababu Naidu at the Velgonda Feeder Canal.

years and expedited works after assuming office in 2024. It also disbursed Rs 768 crore to displaced families within 48 days, announced Rs 169 crore for excluded beneficiaries and Rs 2 lakh compensation for those turning 18.

The project is expected to strengthen irrigation, encourage crop diversification, horticulture and agro-processing, generate rural employment, reduce groundwater dependence and help curb migration.

After dedicating Phase-I of the Velgonda Project to the nation, Naidu said the project would bring water to the drought-hit region and transform Velgonda

into a "golden hill" that would bring light to people's lives. "We gave our word, completed the project and brought the Krishna water from now on, we will create wealth," he said. Addressing farmers who fought drought, fluoride contamination and generations that had waited for water, Naidu said the arrival of Krishna waters would give them a new lease of life.

Naidu said Velgonda represented the resolve to defeat drought, three decades of struggle and confidence in the future of farmers. It also marked an end to sorrier tales of hardships on the drought-hit land.

He said that the project would bring water to the drought-hit region and transform Velgonda into a "golden hill" that would bring light to people's lives. "We gave our word, completed the project and brought the Krishna water from now on, we will create wealth," he said. Addressing farmers who fought drought, fluoride contamination and generations that had waited for water, Naidu said the arrival of Krishna waters would give them a new lease of life.

Naidu said Velgonda represented the resolve to defeat drought, three decades of struggle and confidence in the future of

Focus on West Asia conflict as PM meets Iran Prez in Bishkek

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India is concerned by the escalation of tensions in West Asia and supports all efforts aimed at lasting peace in the region. Prime Minister Narendra Modi told Iranian President Masoud Peshkian on Monday, while simultaneously calling for freedom of navigation and protection of civilians and civil infrastructure.



PM Narendra Modi with Iranian President Masoud Peshkian (left) and Armenian PM Nikol Pashinyan in Bishkek.

Modi and Peshkian met for the first time since the start of the Iran-US conflict in February on the margins of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in the Kyrgyz capital of Bishkek. The two leaders also reviewed bilateral relations against the backdrop of trade ties and cooperation for the development of Iran's Chabahar port being impacted by US sanctions. "We had a discussion on the prevailing situation in the region. India will continue to support all efforts aimed at ensuring lasting peace," Modi said on social media after the meeting.

According to a readout from the external affairs ministry, Modi expressed concern at the escalation of tensions in the region and reiterated India's consistent position that all issues must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy."

Modi reiterated the need for continued efforts to ensure lasting peace and stability in West Asia, which India describes as part of its extended neighbourhood and is home to more than 10 million Indian nationals.

"Calling for safeguarding the freedom of navigation and commerce, he [Modi] emphasised that civilians and civilian infrastructure, including commercial shipping and seafarers, must not be

harmd under any circumstances," the readout stated.

India has had to strike a delicate balance between maintaining its historic ties with Iran and its expressions of solidarity with Gulf Arab states, which have repeatedly been targeted by the Iranian military for housing US military bases. However, the Indian side has also been angered by Iranian attacks on merchant vessels near the Strait of Hormuz that have killed and injured Indian seafarers.

The Indian side has also had to work with Iran and the United Arab Emirates (UAE), which are on opposite sides of the West Asia conflict, to forge consensus ahead of the Brics Summit in September. Support from both the Brics member states is needed to adopt a summit declaration by consensus.

India-Iran relations also figured in the meeting and Modi said he reiterated New Delhi's commitment to strengthen the long-standing friendship with Tehran

across diverse sectors. "We want to expand and diversify our trade basket in the times to come," Modi also pointed to India's readiness to cooperate closely with Iran in multilateral organisations such as Brics and SCO, and said he looked forward to welcoming Peshkian to India for the Brics Summit in September.

Peshkian expressed appreciation for India's "support and cooperation" with Iran during the war and emphasised the need to intensify diplomatic efforts to establish peace and security in West Asia, the Iranian embassy said in a statement. He referred to India's "important position and capacities in the region" and asked Modi to use "India's extensive contacts with various parties to help them move away from the path of war and bloodshed and return to the path of dialogue and agreement."

Iran's efforts have focused on peace and security and resolving issues through dialogue, while the "Americans have chosen the path

of war, insecurity and imposing their will through force", Peshkian said.

Referring to understandings between the parties to the conflict, Peshkian said Iran remains committed to "obligations it has undertaken within the framework of the agreements", but the US has "failed to fulfil its commitments".

Peshkian emphasised Iran's readiness to deepen relations with India in political, economic, scientific, cultural and other areas of mutual interest. The discussions covered collaboration in transportation and maritime affairs, and progress in cooperation at Chabahar port, the Iranian embassy said.

Peshkian referred to efforts by the US to "create restrictions and obstacles" to Iran's cooperation with other countries, and said, "Despite the pressures and restrictions being imposed in an attempt to obstruct Iran's relations with other countries, Tehran is ready to expand its cooperation with India across various fields."

MODI HOLDS TALKS WITH KYRGYZSTAN, ARMENIA LEADERS

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi met the leaders of Armenia and Kyrgyzstan on Monday and reviewed bilateral cooperation in key areas such as defence, trade and technology.

"India-Armenia cooperation is all set to grow in defence, IT, space, education, pharmaceuticals and more," Modi said on social media after his talks with Armenian PM Nikol Pashinyan. "We are equally certain to deepen trade and investment linkages in the times to come."

Their discussions also focused on strengthening cooperation in science and technology, culture and education.

They also exchanged views on regional and global developments, including the situation in West Asia.

Pashinyan briefed Modi on the implementation of the Armenia-Azerbaijan Peace Agreement.

Modi described his meeting with Kyrgyz President Sadyr Zhaparov as "very fruitful" and said their discussions focused on adding momentum to the bilateral strategic partnership through enhanced cooperation in healthcare, pharmaceuticals, IT, minerals, agriculture, digital technologies and infrastructure.

Amid NRC calls, Census postponed in Manipur

Pravesh Lama and Thomas Ngangom
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/IMPHAL: The Union government on Monday deferred the 2027 census in Manipur amid mounting violence and demands by large chunks of the population to update the National Register of Citizens (NRC) before conducting the population enumeration exercise.

THE DECISION CAME AFTER AMIT SHAH CHAIRED A HIGH-LEVEL REVIEW MEETING IN DELHI

3 DEAD, 1 INJURED AS FRESH VIOLENCE ROCKS KANGPOKPI

Thomas Ngangom
letters@hindustantimes.com

held, pending further notification from the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India, amid petitions seeking implementation of NRC before the census.

Since August 16, Manipur was rocked by protests by Naga and Meitei organisations that demanded NRC before the census. The Kuki-Zo communities are opposed to the census. Since August 16, Manipur was rocked by protests by Naga and Meitei organisations that demanded NRC before the census. The Kuki-Zo communities are opposed to the census.

Since August 16, Manipur was rocked by protests by Naga and Meitei organisations that demanded NRC before the census. The Kuki-Zo communities are opposed to the census. Since August 16, Manipur was rocked by protests by Naga and Meitei organisations that demanded NRC before the census. The Kuki-Zo communities are opposed to the census.

IMPHAL: Three people were killed and one other was injured in a fresh attack by unknown armed miscreants at Telkhang Kuki village in Kangpokpi district of Manipur on Monday, while three houses were reportedly set ablaze, police said.

In response to police, the incident took place at around 7.40 am and the deceased have been identified as Hoikhoneng, 20, Nemeichong, 19, Lhumi, 52, (both women) and Lamintang, 35 and, while Lamintang's father identified as Selun sustained injuries.

However the details and number of the injured are yet to be ascertained.

The development came a day before house-listing of the census exercise was scheduled to begin in the strict-torn state where nearly 300 have died since May 2023.

The meeting held at the ministry of home affairs was attended by the governor of Manipur, Shri Ajay Kumar Bhalla, chief minister Shri Yumnam Khenchhand Singh, home secretary Shri Govind Mohan, along with other senior officials. The meeting discussed in detail the demand raised by the people of Manipur to defer the Census exercise in the State before the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC). The meeting agreed to defer the proposed census exercise in the state considering the feelings and aspirations of the people of Manipur," the statement said.

The census exercise has been disrupted by violence in the past—such as Assam in 1981 and Jammu and Kashmir in 1991—but this is the first time that the 2027 exercise has been hit.

The first phase of Census 2027 (house listing) in Manipur was scheduled from September 1 to 30. The self-enumeration facility was set to be available from August 17 to 31. Amid protests and training of census workers being disrupted by local, self-enumeration house listing was also not started.

The decision came on a day the Manipur high court directed that the house-listing exercise be with-

held, pending further notification from the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India, amid petitions seeking implementation of NRC before the census. Since August 16, Manipur was rocked by protests by Naga and Meitei organisations that demanded NRC before the census. The Kuki-Zo communities are opposed to the census.

Local residents alleged that the attack was carried out by armed Naga militants groups however, however, the allegation could not be verified independently.

Police said heavy gunfire and explosives were heard from the area and an investigation has been launched to ascertain the identity of the miscreants.

Meanwhile, Kuki GSO Coordinating Committee, Kangpokpi claimed the attack was an "unprovoked and barbaric attack" allegedly carried out by armed cadres of the NSCN (IM) and its proxy ZUP (K).

Committee on Tribal Unity (CoTU), a Kuki-Zo apex body, has announced a 24-hour total shutdown along the National Highway-2 (Imphal-Dimapur) with effect from 5 am of September 1 to condemn the Monday attack, said a statement issued by the committee.

The statement added that the shutdown is being observed in protest against alleged continuous attacks on Kuki-Zo people.

TASL inks MoU to make Javelin missile in India

Rahul Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Tata Advanced Systems Limited and the Javelin Joint Venture (JJV)—a partnership between Raytheon, an RTX business, and Lockheed Martin—have signed an MoU to co-produce the Javelin All Up Round (AUR) in India, the firms announced.

This comes days after the Indian Army signed a letter of offer and acceptance (LOA) to buy the Javelin anti-tank guided missile system from the United States through its foreign military sales process, a move the US said would further deepen bilateral defence cooperation.

"Tata Advanced Systems has been selected by JJV as the prime partner for future in-country co-production efforts following an evaluation of multiple companies based on capability and expertise," said the joint statement issued in Orlando on Sunday. Under the industry MoU, TASL and the JJV will explore establishing a final assembly and integration facility for the Javelin AUR (fully assem-

THE JAVELIN IS DESIGNED TO BE USED AGAINST SEVERAL TARGETS, LIKE ARMoured VEHICLES AND FORTIFIED POSITIONS

bled missile) and component production capabilities in India, the firms added.

The Javelin is used by the US Army, US Marine Corps, and several others. It is designed for use against a wide array of targets, including armoured vehicles and fortified positions.

The LOA was signed nine months after the US State Department approved the possible sale of the weapon system to the Indian Army following New Delhi's request. Last week, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gorr said, "The Javelin agreement demonstrates the depth of US support for the Indian Army and creates new opportunities for our defence industries to work together."

RSS CENTENARY FINALE LIKELY IN DELHI ON NOV 29

Smriti Kak Ramachandran
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) plans to conclude its ongoing centenary celebrations with a programme in the national capital in November, to be addressed by its chief Mohan Bhagwat, people aware of the details said.

The RSS, founded in 1925 in Nagpur, is the ideological fountainhead of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party. Its centenary celebrations began last year on Vijaydashami (October 2).

The celebrations began in Nagpur and will conclude with a programme in Delhi, to be addressed by sarsanghachalak Mohan Bhagwat. As part of the celebrations, programmes were held across India and abroad," a functionary said. The Delhi programme is likely to be held on November 29. Bhagwat is on a three-nation tour. He has addressed gatherings in Canada and the United States, and is scheduled to arrive in the United Kingdom on Wednesday. The visits are part of the RSS's global outreach aimed at changing the narrative around the Sangh.

Quad energy ministers to meet on G20 sidelines

Shashank Mattoo
letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: In a first for the four-nation Quad grouping, energy ministers of India, Australia, the United States and Japan will meet on the sidelines of the G20 energy ministerial in Houston in the second week of September, HT has learnt. The meeting will mark the inaugural gathering of the Quad's Fuel Security Forum as the four nations attempt to shore up their energy security amid disruptions caused by the present conflict in West Asia. Union power minister Manohar Lal Khattar is expected to represent India at the meet.

People aware of the matter told HT that the focus of the meeting will be on joint cooperation in strategic petroleum reserves, with Washington interested in its possibility of leasing space in the Strategic Petroleum Reserve to India and Japan. The meeting may also focus on providing technical support to Quad countries to enhance their own domestic reserves.

The Quad announced plans to convene the Fuel Security Forum in May this year, after the foreign

THE FOUR NATIONS WILL ATTEMPT TO SHORE UP THEIR ENERGY SECURITY AMID DISRUPTIONS CAUSED BY WEST ASIA CONFLICT

ministers met in New Delhi. It will likely be the first time Quad ministers will meet in a structured format outside of the foreign ministers dialogue.

The Quad nations had agreed to support each other's energy needs as well as those of Indo-Pacific nations during "restricted global energy markets".

The disruption caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz—a major artery of global energy—in the aftermath of the US-Iran war formed a key part of the deliberations when the FMs met in May this year.

The Quad will also support the energy needs of regional nations, building on India's energy diplomacy in South Asia as well as Japan and Australia's efforts in Southeast Asia.

9 Naga MLAs urge Shah to act against Kuki-Zos over 'attacks'

Pravesh Lama
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Nine MLAs, belonging to the Naga community, from the ruling coalition government in Manipur have demanded Union home minister Amit Shah to take immediate action against Kuki-Zo leaders over their alleged role in the killing of Naga civilians.

In a letter to Shah, the MLAs, including deputy chief minister Losai Diko, have also sought action against deputy chief minister Nemecha Kipgen, who belongs to the Kuki-Zo community for allegedly colluding with Kuki militant groups led by her husband, Thangboi Kipgen, a Kuki National Front-Progressive (KNF-P) leader.

The MLAs sent the letter in the backdrop of Naga-Kuki clashes that started in February and has led to over 30 deaths and hundreds of houses burnt.

THE MLAs ALSO SOUGHT ACTION AGAINST KIPGEN FOR ALLEGEDLY COLLUDING WITH KUKI MILITANT GROUPS LED BY HER HUSBAND

HT has a copy of the letter in which they have demanded action against Kuki-Zo leader, including deputy CM Kipgen and arrest of her husband. Thangboi Kipgen is a part of the insurgent groups that are in a Suspension of Operations (SoO) pact with the Centre. The MLA also demanded the immediate abrogation of the pact, with all Kuki militant groups, in view of repeated violations and acts of terror against civilians.

"With deep concern for restoring

ing normalcy in the State of Manipur, we, the undersigned Naga MLAs, submit this earnest appeal for your immediate intervention. The current human tragedy unfolding in Manipur has reached a critical and volatile state, with grave ramifications affecting all aspects of public life. If unaddressed, decisive and bold action is not taken without delay, the State may descend into an uncontrollable situation," the letter, submitted by deputy CM Losai Diko in Shah's Delhi office on Monday, said.

The MLAs asked Shah to initiate action against "Deputy CM Nemecha Kipgen as her office is colluding with the Kuki militant group led by her husband KNF-P, which have become very difficult for the people to comprehend the peace process taken by the government," HT reached out to Kipgen for a comment but it is yet to receive her response.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of **HT TWTW**
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.



FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



Death toll in Nepal floods nears 1K, missing counts surges to 4.5K

HTC And Agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Rescuers struggled on Monday through mud and debris for a sixth day, as the number of missing people soared to nearly 4,500 since devastating flash floods ravaged Nepal on August 26, claiming at least 939 lives, even more than 10,000 people have been rescued so far.

Meanwhile, India stepped up its relief and rescue efforts in coordination with Nepalese authorities, with the ministry of external affairs saying the number of Indian nationals rescued in Nepal stands at 158.

Update on Indian nationals & India's rescue and relief efforts in Nepal Number of Indians rescued: 158 As of 2100 hrs, 31 August 2026. MEA spokesperson Randeep Jaiswal said in a post on X. The flash floods, triggered by a collapse or avalanche of ice and rock near the Nepal-Tibet border, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal on August 26. The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydro-power projects.

The disaster also killed 16 people on the Chinese side, while nearly 500 people remain missing in Tibet, Chinese media reports. Hospitals across Nepal have been witnessing crowds of people looking for their missing relatives. The focus is increasingly shifting towards identifying the dead. Photographs have been posted outside hospitals walls, where huge gatherings could be seen scanning them.

Only a few dozen of the hundreds of bodies recovered were identified till Monday, with authorities saying many remains likely to be decomposed, or difficult to recognise after prolonged exposure to floodwaters. Of the 3,925 people still missing in Nepal, at least 950 are foreign nationals, including 158 from India, officials said on Monday.

Among the Indian nationals missing in Nepal, 32 are from Uttar Pradesh. According to the state relief commissioner's office,

till Monday, the locations of 10 people who were being made to locate the remaining 22. The state government has launched a helpline 1070 to assist the people whose family members are missing in Nepal. People from various districts have registered the details of the missing family members, who are trying to locate the missing family members. "Up relief commissioner Yashod R Bhaskar said.

In Maharashtra, officials said that 406 people from various parts of the state were stranded in flash floods-ravaged Nepal, of them 64 are yet to be traced. Those missing include 60 members of a single group that had travelled with the MEA and our embassies in Nepal and China. There is hardly any hope left for the survival of these people," said an official from Mantralaya.

In West Bengal, officials said at least 37 people from the state, mostly pilgrims, remained missing after being stuck in the devastating flash floods while on their way to Kailash-Manasarovar in Tibet. Those missing include a team of 32 members, who were going on the yatra with the Kolkata-based Buddhist group.

Initially 39 were reported missing. Family members and state government management to establish contact with a couple from Basirhat. They returned safely on Sunday. The remaining 37 are still missing," said a senior IPS officer in state.

Odisha officials said four people from the state, including a couple, are still missing.

In Gujarat, officials said at least 25 people from the state are missing. "We have been sharing the details of the missing persons with the MEA, which forwards the information to the Nepal Embassy and, subsequently, the Nepal government. However, we have not received any update on the 25 people from Gujarat so far," a government official said.

(With inputs from state bureaus)

Search continues at hydro project sites

Rescuers from across agencies were toiling to save people trapped in collapsed structures at 11 hydropower sites

600+ People still untraced across Nepal's hydro projects

ONE FACILITY, 570 MISSING Most of the missing are at Upper Trishuli-1 project, where 570 people, including 99 Indians, are untraced. Three workers were rescued on Monday, but it's unclear if they were among those trapped inside tunnels.



Race against time as 600 remain trapped in hydro project tunnels

Pravesh Lama
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: More than 600 people employed at 11 hydropower project sites in Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts remain missing or trapped inside collapsed tunnels and other infrastructure following the August 26 flash floods in the Himalayan nation, with rescue operations turning exceptionally grim with each passing day.

Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority had estimated 630 people (as on 5pm on Monday) to be missing at these hydropower sites. People aware of the matter said most of those missing were employed at the Upper Trishuli-1 project in Rasuwadi district, where around 570 people, including 99 Indians, are yet to be traced. On Monday, three people missing from this project site were res-

cued, officials said, adding none of them were trapped inside a tunnel. "Of these 570, there are at least 300 believed to be trapped in tunnels. The five firms employed in this project estimate that there were around 1,400 people working within the project that morning (August 26). The number keeps changing but at least 800 workers from here have survived," said an official requesting anonymity.

A 13-member Indian army team of tunnel rescue experts is working with Nepalese authorities to open a route to a powerhouse tunnel. They reached 90 metres inside the 250-m tunnel but could not go inside. At Langtang Khola (41 missing), an inspection was

conducted today (Monday) and work will begin on Tuesday," the official said.

At Rasuwagari (93 missing), drones were used inside a tunnel but no bodies were found, while at Upper Trishuli 3A, where 42 are missing, one portion of the tunnel was opened after a crown blast, the official said. "Work is going on to clear the pile of stones and pathway inside."

Vijay Prasad, a rigger from Bihar's Rohtas district, had a narrow escape at Upper Trishuli 1 site. "Some of us who were at a height saw huge waves coming towards the dam. We knew it would break the dam so we jumped down and ran towards the opened mouth of the tunnel. The wave must have been 50-70m high," Prasad, who was among 150 survivors from the project, said upon reaching home on Sunday. "There were 7 South Korean nationals among the survivors while many are still trapped."



A man walks past damaged houses following flash floods at Devghat in Nepal's Nuwakot district. AP

19-member team from India begins DNA testing in Nepal

Neeraj Chauhan and Praveesh Lama
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A 19-member team of DNA experts from India has begun a painstaking task of collecting, preserving and analysing biological samples to identify hundreds of victims of the devastating flash floods in Nepal, and ultimately helping authorities in returning the bodies to their family members.

Divided into six teams, the Indian delegation for Disaster Victim Identification (DVI) comprises 10 experts from the National Forensic Sciences University (NFSU) in Gandhinagar and nine from the Central Forensic Sciences Laboratory (CFSL) in Delhi.

On Monday, the teams, led by Bhargav Patel, head of the Centre of Excellence in DNA Forensics at NFSU, in coordination with experts from Nepal Police's Central Forensic Science Laboratory in Kathmandu and the Forensics Department of the Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital, started collecting biological samples from the bodies — mostly

murdered — as well as from people scattered across the flood zone. The Indian team has been deployed to support Nepal in Disaster Victim Identification (DVI) — a process that involves documenting bodies and body parts, assigning identification numbers, collecting appropriate biological samples and eventually helping authorities reunite relatives with their loved ones.

Director of NFSU, told HT. The larger objective, Junare added, is to help the authorities in Nepal "with identification and ensure that victims receive a dignified final farewell."

Nepal was also part of the forensic scientists' team that helped in identifying the victims of the Air India Flight 17 crash near Ahmedabad airport last year.

Yog Bahadur Pal, a senior Nepal Police officer, said that more than 600 bodies remained unidentified after the August 26 tragedy. "We have collected DNA samples from their teeth, thigh bones, fingerprints, and other specific body parts. We are using a software called Combined DNA Index System (CODIS), which is administered by the FBI as well," Pal said, adding that along with the health department, police have already created a large database of DNA evidence collected from the victims.

Arjun Subedi, a Nepalese home ministry official, said they are coordinating with various embassies seeking assistance in the victim identification process.

"The victims are from different parts of the world. They can give us all embassies offering to take medical records that they send us on email too. It may be difficult for them to travel to Nepal immediately. They can give the blood samples in the hospitals back home and then email us the records through their embassy and we will match it with our records," Subedi said.

MUMBAI DOC AMONG MISSING Days after the devastating flash floods that struck Nepal on August 26, a doctor from Maharashtra's Mumbai remains untraceable among thousands other who went missing after the tragedy. A well-known name in the city, Milind Chitaley's family and friends, recall his love for mountaineering, while hoping of his speedy return.

Chitaley, a medical practitioner from Andheri in Mumbai and founder of Hills and Trails tour company, had been associated with Himalayan mountaineering and expeditions for nearly three decades.

MBA WRITES TO CJ OVER MISSING JUDGE BENGALURU: The Madras Bar Association (MBA) on Monday wrote to the Chief Justice of India seeking "urgent" intervention from the Union government to trace former Madras high court judge, Justice V Sivaniam, who has been untraceable in Nepal since August 26, after flash floods. The MBA wrote to CJ Surya Kant and the Prime Minister's Office, urging efforts to trace the retired judge be "intensified."

In a letter signed by MBA president VA Kamalanathan and secretary J Pothiraj, the Bar urged the CJ to direct the Centre to treat the matter as "urgent and of highest priority" and to take "all possible effort and measures" to search for justice Sivaniam.



Congress workers protest in Karnataka on Monday. @CNDRN

CONGRESS STATES OVER FIR AGAINST RAHUL

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress units across several states held demonstrations on Monday over the arrest of Rahul Gandhi and the filing of an FIR against him in Haldwani after a public rally organised by party president Mallikarjun Kharge, who comes from the Dalit community.

At a press conference on Saturday, Gandhi had demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi order an FIR against those involved in the "shuddhikarn" (purification) of the Ramilla ground in Haldwani. Anil Kumar, a member of the Shree Ram Sena Dhamaraj Sana Santhi, subsequently filed an FIR in Haldwani accusing Gandhi of promoting enmity and ill-will on the basis of religion and caste.

Calicut-based FIR is a "harmless weaponisation of the state machinery to target the LoP", Congress general secretary KC Venugopal directed the party's state and district units to hold massive protest marches on Monday evening to condemn what he described as "vendetta politics" and demand immediate legal action against the BJP workers allegedly involved in the incident. The protests were held in Karnataka, West Bengal, Bihar and Goa.

"Our fight should continue against the ones who attack the values of social justice enshrined in the Constitution," Venugopal said in his letter to state units. Congress leaders Randeep Surjewala and Jairam Ramesh also attacked the BJP over the FIR. "By registering an FIR against Rahul Gandhi, the cowardly BJP government has revealed its true face," Surjewala said in a post on X, referring to Kharke's remarks that the purification of the stage after his speech had hurt his sentiments.

Penguin denies external pressure to not publish Sonia Gandhi's memoir

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Maintaining that there was no external pressure behind its decision to not publish Sonia Gandhi's memoir, Penguin Random House India on Monday said there was an "impassable" part of the book "during discussion on 'Belonging: A Journey of Love'."

The publisher didn't disclose the contentious issue, citing "agreement and author confidentiality."

The fresh clarification comes amid a controversy over the India publication of the Congress leader's much anticipated memoir following an announcement by the US-based Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of Penguin Random House, that the book would be released worldwide on November 10.

Several Congress leaders have raised issues of governmental pressure and freedom of expression. Former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot alleged that pressure was put on Penguin India to remove sections relating to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS and China's occupation of Indian territory during the Modi regime.

In its latest statement, PRHI said it was not under any external pressure that the decision was driven by its outside intervention.

Former TN minister Venkatchalam resigns from DMK **ERODE:** Former minister and DMK leader Thoppu N D Venkatchalam on Monday announced his decision to quit the party. Addressing the media, he said: "It is under circumstances where I cannot continue to travel within the DMK that I have come to the decision to quit the movement today."

However, he clarified that his exit was not driven by friction with DMK president M K Stalin. "There is no shortcoming in the affection between us,"



Sonia Gandhi

"We feel it is important for us to correct certain misrepresentations regarding the forthcoming memoir 'Belonging'. This is a book that we at Penguin Random House India, were really keen on publishing as it was a hard-won acquisition," Pallavi Narayan, spokesperson of PRHI, told HT. "Since the content of the book is confidential and under embargo, there was no external pressure whatsoever," the publisher said.

PRHI said the manuscript had gone through its "normal editorial process" during which several points were raised and deliberated upon with the author's representatives. "On some, they agreed to changes and on others, we accepted the author's position. Unfortunately, and ultimately, an understanding could not be reached on a particular issue," it said.

The author's team subsequently informed the publisher that they did not wish to proceed with the book. PRHI said, adding that it respected their decision.

11 killed in firecracker factory blast in PP

HT Correspondent
letters@htlive.com

PRAYAGRAJ: Eleven people, including several minors, were killed and more than a dozen were injured in an explosion at an alleged illegal firecracker factory in Uttar Pradesh's Kaushambi district on Monday, police said, adding a probe has been launched to ascertain the cause of the blast and to determine whether children were being employed at the factory.

While chief minister Yogi Adityanath expressed sorrow over the tragedy and directed officials to ensure the best possible medical treatment for the injured, the state government announced compensation of ₹2 lakh for the next of kin of the deceased.



Smoke erupts from charred remains after an explosion in a firecracker factory in Pipri area of Kaushambi on Monday.

deceased and ₹50,000 for the people with serious injuries. According to police, the explosion occurred at around 11 am in the factory located in Chulashabazi village of Charva under Pipari police station limits

5 GET LIFE TERM IN 2024 GUJ NAVRATRI GANGLA CASE

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

AHMEDABAD: Five men have been sentenced to life imprisonment for the gang rape of a 16-year-old girl during the Navratri celebrations in 2024 in Gujarat's Bhuj area, said a Vadodra special court on Monday.

The order passed by the Vadodra Bench of the Gujarat High Court on August 20 for crime that took place on October 4, 2024, when the girl was returning from a garba event with a friend.

The court has sentenced all five convicts to life imprisonment, which means they will remain in jail till their last breath. The court has also ordered compensation of ₹10 lakh for the victim, district government pleader Anil Desai, appearing for the prosecution said, adding that the court also imposed a collective fine of ₹1 lakh on the five convicts under various sections of law.

While the prosecution on August 25 sought the death penalty for one, or in the alternative, life imprisonment for the five men, the defence sought minimum punishment, citing the fact that the convicts were married and had families and children.

Desai opposed the defence's plea and argued that such a punishment would not be adequate considering the gravity of the offence.

20.6mn voters excluded from draft electoral roll after Maharashtra SIR

Surendra P Gangan and Saubhag Kulshrestha
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: As many as 20.68 million voters, roughly 21.4% of the Maharashtra's previous voter base, have been dropped from the draft electoral roll following the special intension revision (SIR), the chief electoral officer said on Monday.

These people have not been included in the draft as their enumeration forms were uncollectable because they were either untraceable, deceased, or had shifted residences, they said. In Mumbai, 24.7% of the names have been deleted, while the number is even higher for Thane district, where 38.3% of voters have been dropped — the highest for any district in the state.

Voters whose names are missing from the draft rolls, those who require corrections and others who want to file objections must do so by September 30 along with supporting documents. This constitutes the next phase of the SIR exercise. The final draft electoral roll will be published on November 4.

Breaking down the figures, the office of the state chief electoral officer said that as many as 17.85 lakh of the 20.68 million registered electors, as many as

comprising police, fire brigade personnel, and district administration officials immediately rushed to the site and launched search and relief operations.

Superintendent of police (SP) Sayanvaran Prasad said the FIR had been registered against six members of a family — Naudash, Shaleel, Shabana, Kalksha Bano, Naudash's son Adil and Shaleel's daughter Saina. The FIR alleged that the family was involved in the large-scale illegal manufacture and storage of firecrackers inside a residential premises without adequate safety measures. The case has been registered under various BNS sections, including 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), and relevant sections of the Explosives Act.

compiling police, fire brigade personnel, and district administration officials immediately rushed to the site and launched search and relief operations.

Superintendent of police (SP) Sayanvaran Prasad said the FIR had been registered against six members of a family — Naudash, Shaleel, Shabana, Kalksha Bano, Naudash's son Adil and Shaleel's daughter Saina. The FIR alleged that the family was involved in the large-scale illegal manufacture and storage of firecrackers inside a residential premises without adequate safety measures. The case has been registered under various BNS sections, including 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), and relevant sections of the Explosives Act.

Initial reports suggest that around 25 workers were present inside the factory when the accidents occurred. Rescue teams

IN MUMBAI, 34.75% NAMES HAVE BEEN DELETED, WHILE 38.37% HAVE BEEN REMOVED IN THANE DISTRICT

20,688,487 electors, or 21.4%, have been excluded from the draft electoral rolls who could not be traced at their given addresses during the SIR exercise.

This includes 1.76 million voters who were excluded because they were registered at more than one polling booth, 7.68 million have permanently shifted, 7.55 million are absent from their given addresses, 3.48 million are deceased, 1.76 million were registered in more than one constituency. Another 223,000 refused to register despite being found at their respective addresses.

"When one accounts for duplicate voters and deceased voters, the actual number excluded from the draft rolls totals to 15.6 million," election officials said.

CENTRE ON CJP FIRS

before a bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Tuesday. Solicitor general Tuskar Mehta mentioned the application before the CJI and sought an early hearing, saying the Centre was seeking to resolve the issue concerning the FIRs.

If approved by the top court, Delhi will be the first of six states and Union territories — where FIRs were filed against student protesters — to quash the FIRs. To be sure, states such as Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, West Bengal and Maharashtra have announced that they will not take any legal action against people participating in protests. But in no state have FIRs been withdrawn.

The move comes days before the proposed September 5 protest march announced by the CJP from India Gate to the Delhi Police headquarters, with withdrawal of FIRs against student protesters being one of the principal demands. The Supreme Court on Monday declined to interfere with the proposed march, leaving the question of law-and-order arrangements to the Centre and Delhi government while expressing confidence that all stakeholders would act peacefully and within the legal framework.

In its application, the Delhi Police said that pursuant to a decision taken by the central government on July 25, it "no longer wishes to pursue" the 13 FIRs registered in connection with the CJP protests between July 20 and 25.

The cases include allegations of rioting, attempt to murder, damage to public property, assault on police personnel and other offences under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act.

The police, however, said that 2,873 individuals with "serious criminal antecedents," according to the National Crime Records Bureau database, were prima facie reported to have been present at the protest site.

The investigation is required to ascertain their role, if any, in the commission of offences relating to bodily harm or destruction of property at the said protests," said the application. It, therefore, sought the court's permission to register a single fresh FIR against these 2,873 persons. The proposed investigation would be confined to determining their individual roles in offences relating to bodily harm or destruction of property during the protests.

The Delhi Police also made it clear that no fresh FIR will be filed thereafter in relation to the incidents covered by the application.

It further said that if any other FIR relating to the same incidents, but not included in the list of 13 cases, was subsequently found or brought to the authorities' attention, the state would not oppose the affected party seeking similar relief from the Supreme Court.

The Centre urged the Supreme Court to exercise its Article 142 powers "in the larger public interest and in the peculiar facts of this case" to quash the 13 FIRs and permit registration of the one fresh case. It also requested the court to clarify that any order passed in the matter would be confined to the "peculiar facts" of the case and would not constitute a precedent.

The application was filed in proceedings arising from petitions concerning the July 20 protests, during which Delhi Police and the Rapid Action Force used force, including lathi charge, tear gas and pellet guns, to prevent protesters from marching towards Parliament.

The Supreme Court has already constituted a five-member high-powered enquiry committee headed by former Supreme Court judge Justice R Subhash Reddy to conduct an independent inquiry into competing allegations arising from the protests. The HPEC is examining allegations of excessive and unlawful use of force by the police as well as allegations of violence by protesters, injuries to police personnel and damage to public property.

The CJP first garnered millions of followers on social media before launching an indefinite sit-in protest on June 20 demanding the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over repeated question paper leaks — including one earlier this year. After days of tepid crowds, the movement was galvanised by the hunger strike and forcible removal of activist Sonam Wangchuk.

On July 20, columns of people — many of them students, first-time agitators and young professionals — defied a steady drizzle and police barricading to join what became the largest street protests in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's third term.

After the July 20 protests, crowds swelled and spilled beyond the confines of Jantar Mantar as thousands of young people poured into central Delhi, despite the longest spells of internet shutdown and mass media blackout in Delhi.

ers grew, the government's efforts to break the impasse kicked into overdrive. Nodia and Singh convinced Wangchuk to break his fast. Modi made a rare personal appeal to young people on Instagram and promised a stringent new bill — which was eventually passed in the monsoon session — to tackle paper leaks, and the National Testing Agency fired top officials.

Eventually, the sit-in was called off on July 25 after Pradhan's resignation. During the meeting with CJP members on June 25, Union minister JP Nadda said the CJP representatives came to the meeting with a written draft on cases filed during the July 20 agitation. "After the discussion, the trial was that no action should be taken and no FIRs should be filed. If any FIRs have already been registered, whether by the Delhi Police or in BJP-ruled states, it will be withdrawn," Nadda said.

GDP NUMBERS

rates producer price indices, has also made an upward revision to the GDP numbers in the quarter ending March 2026, which were published in June. March quarter growth now stands at 8.6% compared to 7.8% according to the data released by the NSO in June. This means that growth did slow down after the outbreak of the war.

None of this negates the fact that India's domestic growth drivers shielded it from a large deceleration on account of the war. Disaggregated GDP numbers support this assessment. Private Final Consumption Expenditure (PFCE) and Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF) grew at 7.8% and 11.9%, respectively, in the June quarter. Exports too grew at an impressive 12%, even as imports contracted by 1.1% in real terms. At the sector-wise level, services gave the biggest boost to growth with a 10% rise. Manufacturing saw a growth of 9.2%. "Growth continues to be supported by resilient domestic demand, sustained expansion in manufacturing and services activity, and robust exports, reaffirming India's position as the world's fastest-growing major economy," RBI's MPC had said in its latest resolution published on August 1.

What is also discernible in the latest data is the fiscal cost of the war. This is best seen in the Gross Value Added (GVA) growth being 8.2%, greater than its GDP counterpart. GVA is GDP less net indirect taxes. Growth in net indirect taxes fell to 3.9% in quarter ending June 2026 compared to 6% a year ago. High frequency data released by the NSO along with GDP num-

bers also shows a large rise in fertilizer subsidy spending in the June quarter.

The 7.8% GDP growth number is well ahead of previous RBI projections and a Bloomberg poll of economists, which had given a median estimate of 7.3% for this number. To be sure, some analysts did see this coming. "India's GDP growth for the April-June quarter could print as high as 8%, basking fears that India's economy was dented by the Middle East conflict. Strong high frequency data — autos, credit, exports and corporate earnings — have been presaging this outcome for a while," Sajid Chinoy, Chief India Economist at JP Morgan, had said in a note released on Sunday. Chinoy's note attributed the impressive growth performance to three factors. A joint fiscal-monetary-regulatory stimulus in 2025, which included tax cuts and interest rate reduction, acceleration in exports due to currency depreciation, reduction in US tariffs and higher global growth; and a "swift and nimble" policy response to the supply shock for petroleum products. However, the note cautions that "much of the recent pick-up is cyclical in nature, induced by tax cuts and lower interest rates and fuelled by strong credit. At some point, these impulses will wane, and growth rates will be shaped by the structural underpinnings of the economy".

"GDP growth surprised to the upside, but still slipped vs an upwardly revised Q4FY26. This outperformance poses upside risk to our FY27 growth forecast of 6.8% y/y. As growth outpaced the RBI's estimate, we acknowledge the risk of a December hike, but that is not our base case," Aastha Gudwani, India Chief Economist at Barclays, said in a note.

MODI MEETS PUTIN in the discussions, the external affairs ministry said. "Every day spent perpetuating war pushes humanity backwards, and every step taken towards peace fills the whole of humanity with new hope and enthusiasm. We must move from endless war towards the end of war, which is very necessary for the well-being of humanity," Modi said in televised opening remarks at the meeting with Putin.

"A peaceful resolution of all issues as soon as possible is the call of humanity, and this is also India's message. The land of Gandhi and Buddha has one message — the path of peace," he said, speaking in Hindi.

Modi noted that he and Putin had always discussed the Ukraine issue at all their meetings, and India "supports all efforts for peace and will continue to do so in future".

The remarks were largely in line with those made by Modi in past engagements with Putin — at their meeting following the start of the Ukraine conflict in September 2022, Modi had said that "today's era is not of war", while at a meeting in Moscow in July 2024, Modi had pointed out that "no solution to the conflict is possible on the battlefield".

Modi and Putin are set to meet again within less than a fortnight when the Russian leader travels to New Delhi to participate in the Brics Summit to be held on September 12-13. Modi referred to Putin as "my friend" and said all Indians were eager to welcome him and his delegation as the visit will "strengthen bilateral relations and empower discussions and cooperation within Brics".

The two leaders also reviewed various aspects of bilateral relations, including cooperation in trade, investment, and energy and fertilizer security. Modi referred to Putin's visit to India for the annual bilateral summit last December and said the meeting had taken economic cooperation to new heights.

"It is a matter of great satisfaction that our cooperation is continuously moving towards new heights and we are working together for the benefit of the people of both countries," Modi said. "Moving forward while keeping national interests above all else is what we both believe in and this will be our formula in the future too."

Putin said Russia-India relations have become stronger because of the bilateral special and privileged strategic partnership. "This is undoubtedly facilitated by your personal attention to the development of the Russia-India relations, as well as by the close personal friendship that has developed between us," he said.

Putin also noted that bilateral trade turnover increased by 2.6% in the first half of 2026 after a slight decline last year. India is "among the leaders" in terms of foreign students in Russia, as the number of Indian students increased seven-fold over the past decade and now stands at almost 40,000, he said.

The discussions between the two leaders covered key areas of

cooperation such as defence, energy, mobility of workers, innovation, space, fertilisers and people-to-people contacts. They also discussed regional and global issues, including the "conflicts in West Asia and the Black Sea region which have impacted maritime trade and the safety and security of Indian seafarers", the external affairs ministry said. Modi and Putin agreed to strengthen the bilateral special and privileged strategic partnership, which has registered significant growth and "shown resilience in the backdrop of geopolitical uncertainties".

Foreign secretary Vikram Misra acknowledged at a media briefing after the meeting that the growing imbalance in two-way trade and the need to expand Indian exports to Russia had figured in the discussions. He pointed out that Modi had shared a paper with Putin at last year's annual summit that detailed market access-related issues faced by Indian products and non-tariff barriers.

"I am glad to report that, with the cooperation of our Russian friends, we've had significant progress on that front and market access has improved significantly in several areas of interest, including meat exports, marine products exports, dairy exports as well," Misra said.

Both sides will work to increase access to Russian markets and diversify the trade basket to address the growing trade deficit, he said. Misra responded to a question on the problem of Indian nationals also being recruited into the Russian Army to fight in the war in Ukraine by saying that India's embassy in Moscow is monitoring the situation to ensure the release and repatriation of these citizens.

He noted that a total of 227 Indians had so far been recruited into the Russian military and 139 were discharged while 51 had died. "We are in discussions with the Russian side to ensure that any cases that remain are discharged at the earliest so that we can return these people to their families," he said.

Following their meeting, Modi and Putin travelled together in the Russian President's limousine to the venue of the inaugural ceremony of the World Nomad Games, just as they had done after a meeting on the margins of the SCO Summit in Tianjin last year. Footage beamed on television showed them jointly entering the venue.

2 Indians killed in US, mutual friend arrested

Vishnu Varma

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A woman from Kerala has been arrested in the US's California in connection with the alleged murder of two other women from the state. The victims' families said on Monday.

The victims were identified as Anjana Hari (35), a native of Thrissur district and Ann Mary Mathew (40) from Thiruvananthapuram district. Their mutual friend, Anila (32), a native of Kottayam district, has been apprehended by the Milpitas police department in San Jose, California and is suspected to be behind both the murders, purportedly committed within a span of a few minutes on August 28.

Families and officials in Kerala confirmed that while Anjana succumbed to injuries in a hit-and-run collision in Milpitas, Ann was found dead with a single stab wound at her home in San Jose.

"When officers arrived, they found a female victim who had sustained significant injuries as a result of the collision. Unfortunately, she was pronounced deceased at the scene. Officers quickly searched the surrounding area and found a blue SUV matching the description in a nearby parking lot. The driver, a 32-year-old Milpitas resident, was arrested in connection with the incident," the police said in a statement.

The police said that the circumstances surrounding the collision are being determined.

Thiruvir MP Suresh Gopi said he had spoken to India's Consul General in San Francisco regarding the repatriation of the bodies of the victims.

"The Consul General has ordered the local funeral service to proceed with documentation for the repatriation of the bodies. But because they were murders and the police investigation is on, there could be a delay," said Gopi.

CONG: 'SAMUDRA MANTHAN' MADE TO BENEFIT ADANI

Pragati Chawla

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Congress on Monday alleged that the government's \$84,084 crore Samudra Manthan Scheme was designed to benefit the Adani-Welspun group, calling the scheme a "scam" and accusing the centre of favouring private businesses over public sector companies and MSMEs.

"From the government's Samudra Manthan scheme, the poison that emerges will go to the people's share, and the nectar that emerges will go to Adani's share," said Congress MP Shaktikant Gohil. "₹84,084 crore is included in the first phase of this Samudra Manthan scheme. Those who will drill wells in the sea to search for oil and gas will get 50% directly from the Government of India to the businessman," he said, further alleging that Adani-Welspun already had three blocks with exploration clearances in place.

HT reached out to the Adani-Welspun group but did not get a response till the story went to print.

CID DETAINS BJP LEADER IN KPSC JOB FRAUD PROBE

BENGALURU: The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) has detained BJP leader Basavaraj Kannale in Delhi in connection with alleged irregularities in the KPSC recruitment of 400 Veterinary Officers, and is questioning his suspected links with IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gongwar, who was taken into custody in the same case.

Kannale, a BJP functionary from Bidar, is being brought to Bengaluru and is expected to be produced before a court late on Monday. The CID is likely to seek his custody for further questioning.

Investigators suspect Kannale may have been involved in a network in which middlemen allegedly demanded ₹80 lakh for each Veterinary Officer post, with ₹40 lakh sought as an advance. The money was allegedly sought to manipulate OMR answer sheets and leak question papers to increase candidates' marks.

Kannale is a syndicate member of Tumakuru University and has business interests including the travel sector.

He owns buses and cabs, according to officials. HTC

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.

RELAX. THE WEEKEND'S HERE
HT brunch

EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Aug was warmest ever, Sep to be rain deficient

Jaiveer Gandhok and Pallavi Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Monday forecast below normal rainfall across the country in September—which would mean this monsoon will certainly end on a deficit—and revealed that the preceding month had been the warmest August since 1901.

The deficient and uneven rainfall, which is expected to be less than 91% of the long period average (LPA) this month, is likely to weigh on the kharif crop, with experts seeing lower yields, quality and output.

The overall monsoon deficit stood at 14% on August 31, with this expected to increase through September.

In September, which is the last monsoon month left, the country typically records 167.9mm of rainfall, based on the 1971-2020 LPA. During September, many parts of the country are likely to receive below-normal rainfall. However, some areas of northwest, northeast, east, central India and isolated areas of Southeast Peninsular India, are likely to receive normal to above-normal rainfall, the forecast said.

IMD presented a data, which shows this is the warmest August on record—since 1901, in terms of mean temperature across the country, which was 28.01°C in August, 0.67°C above the LPA. IMD director general M Moha-



The country typically records 167.9 mm of rainfall in September.

patra said while there was significant rainfall across the Indo-Gangetic plain region, where temperatures accordingly remained in check, other parts of the country broadly saw below normal rains and thus, higher temperatures too.

"We had moderate to strong El Niño conditions prevailing through August and while four low pressure systems also developed, the activity was mainly confined across the Indo-Gangetic Plain region. This also included two depressions developing," Mohapatra said, adding rainfall eluded much of the western coast, all the way from Punjab.

The weather department said El Niño was continuing to strengthen and above normal maximum and minimum temperatures are likely to persist in most parts of the country in September. "El Niño should continue to strengthen till about November

and December. El Niño conditions will also prevail during the early winter next year," Mohapatra said.

Further, September should start on a weak note. While significant rainfall may occur in the Himalayan foothills, parts of east India and most parts of East India, it should remain below normal in other parts of the country till around September 9, the short-term forecast also stated.

"The forecast means that this year's rainfall is likely to be below 90% of the LPA. But for agriculture, the total quantum of rainfall is less important than its temporal and spatial distribution. The prospects for a good kharif harvest have already been stunted, and the uneven rainfall pattern is likely to affect yields, quality and the size of the 2026-27 crop," said agriculture minister Nirmala Sitharaman. India set a foodgrain production target of 373.93 million tonnes for the 2026-27 crop year (Jul-Jun), slightly lower than the record 376.56 million tonnes achieved in 2025-26.

"By the end of September, the country is likely to continue to face an uneven rainfall distribution, which will affect kharif crop sowing, yields and output. Across several key crops, including pulses, coarse grains, oilseeds, maize, rice and cotton, is also likely to be lower," Chandrasekhar said.

SC awaits Guv call on MP minister's prosecution

Abraham Thomas
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday decided to await the decision of the Madhya Pradesh governor on grant of sanction to prosecute state minister Kunwar Vijay Shah over his remarks against Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel Chaudhary during Operation Sindoor.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant told the special investigation team (SIT) of Madhya Pradesh that it has completed its investigation against the minister to file its final report before the concerned court the moment sanction is

granted.

Posting the matter after two weeks, the bench, also comprising justices Jayaprakash Narayan and V Mohana Reddy. "The investigation of the SIT is complete and a report has been placed before us in a sealed cover as sanction of the governor is awaited. It is directed that as soon as sanction is granted, the report will be filed before the competent court."

The development came during the hearing of Shah's challenge to an order of the Madhya Pradesh high court, which had taken suo motu cognisance of his remarks referring to Chief Minister Chaudhary as the "sister of terrorism."



Vijay Shah

and directed registration of an FIR against him.

Additional solicitor general (ASG) KM Nataraj, appearing for the state government, told the court that a decision of the gov-

ernor is awaited shortly. "We have forwarded the request to the governor. We are expecting a response in a day or two."

The three-member SIT had informed the court that the sanction was sought as a pre-condition under section 217(1) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Samhita, 2023 (BNS) for the trial court to take cognisance of offences against him.

The SIT was represented in court by DIG Kalyan Chakraborty who urged the bench to take its final report on record.

The bench told DIG that this will not be possible as the competent court alone has the juris-

isdiction to consider this report.

The SIT had earlier informed the court in January that its request for sanction against the minister has been pending with the state government since August 2025, when it submitted its report to the state.

Following this, the court had in January granted two weeks for the state to file a final call.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh, representing Shah, told the court that soon after he made the allegations, the state government made remarks at a public address in Indore, he realised his mistake and offered an apology the next day.

'LESS THAN 1% OF ILLICIT MONEY IS EVER RECOVERED'

Utkarsh Anand
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant has flagged the staggering scale of money laundering and white-collar crime, saying the world launders enough money in a year to buy every one of its eight billion people a modest laptop and still have money left over, while less than 1% of the illicit wealth is ever recovered.

Addressing the closing session of the 43rd International Symposium on Economic Crime at Cambridge on Saturday, Justice Kant used the striking comparison to underline the gap between the scale of economic crime and the ability of legal systems to recover the proceeds.

"If the global estimates on money laundering are even roughly right, the world launders enough money in a single year to buy every one of the eight billion people alive on the planet today a modest laptop, and still have some change left over in the coffers," the CJI said.

He said that of the "immense tide of illicit wealth", less than one unit in a hundred is ever recovered. "For every hundred parts of that wealth, ninety-nine are simply referred to in speeches and reports, while only one part is ever actually put right," he said.

He said India's experience had also demonstrated that recovering illicit assets across borders was often more dependable through mutual legal assistance than through extradition.



7 killed in accident: Assam CM blames NHAI

GUWAHATI: Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday said poor maintenance of roads by the National Highways Authority of India was "responsible" for the tragic accident on NH 27 that left seven people dead a day ago. Senior Congress leader Debabrata Saikia wrote to Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari, seeking suspension of toll collection in the state and a comprehensive audit of all roads where levies are collected from vehicle owners.

9-year-old chasing kite falls in Raj borewell, rescue efforts on

ALWAR: A 9-year-old boy slipped into an open borewell and plunged roughly 45 feet underground while chasing a stray kite in Rajasthan's Ramgarh, triggering an intensive emergency rescue effort. The accident happened when the child stepped onto a stone slab covering the abandoned shaft.

'Less' survival chance for seafarers missing in Ukraine: Centre

NEW DELHI: There is "less" chance of survival of the two Indian seafarers, Deepak Kumar Gupta and Ram Chandra Dubey aboard the cargo ship MV AGN RAGNAR, who went missing on July 25 following a drone attack off the Ukrainian coast, the Centre told the Supreme Court on Monday.

{ SC JUDGE IMPERSONATION CASE }

Sukesh sentenced to 8-year jail

Arnabjit Sur
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has sentenced alleged conman Sukesh Chandrasekar to eight years in prison for allegedly impersonating a Supreme Court judge to influence his case hearing, observing that the convict showed no remorse for his "mendacious actions" and continues to tread on the "road to perdition".

The sentence was handed out by chief judicial magistrate Harshita Mishra of Tis Hazari courts on August 29 and released on Monday.

The court said that Chandrasekar was being handed out a rigorous imprisonment of four years for the offence of Indian Penal Code Section 507 (Criminal intimidation by an anonymous commu-



Sukesh Chandrasekar

nication), two years for Section 170 (Personating a public servant) and two years for Section 189 (Threat of injury to public servant).

The court said that the sentences cannot be permitted to merge into one another or to operate merely concurrently.

"The nature of the offences, the distinct mischief addressed by each provision, the manner in which the offences were committed

and, most importantly, their cumulative impact upon the administration and justice makes this a fit and compelling case for consecutive sentences," the court stated.

The judge said, "Where distinct criminal wrongs are deliberately committed, each substantial wrong must be adequately reflected in the punishment."

The court said Chandrasekar first impersonated the private secretary of a then sitting Supreme Court judge and later the judge himself in a phone call made on April 28, 2017.

He tried to persuade Poonam Chaudhary, then special judge dealing with Prevention of Corruption Act cases, to grant him bail at the earliest and threatened her with adverse professional consequences if she did not comply.

Goa anti-conversion bill won't be tabled in assembly this session

Gerard de Souza
letters@hindustantimes.com

PANAJI: The controversial anti-conversion bill will not be tabled during the monsoon session of the Goa assembly, which began on Monday, days after the state Cabinet cleared it, a ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) lawmaker said. The government decided against introducing the Goa Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Bill after lawmakers, including from the BJP, met chief minister Pramod Sawant and opposed its introduction, he added.

BJP lawmaker Michael Lobo said the government acted in

haste in having the bill cleared in the Cabinet. He cited the meeting with Sawant and said it was decided there that it would not be introduced. "We need to study [the bill], and everyone's views need to be taken into account. We need to know what the bill is all about. What is happening is wrong. Every person's religious beliefs are important. There should be respect for all religions. Sooner or later there needs to be a discussion on what is good for Goa. Things are moving in the wrong direction," Lobo said.

Independent legislator Alexio Lourenco said he would oppose the legislation if introduced,

even as it was agreed at the meeting with Sawant that the bill would not be introduced. He maintained there is no data to show a high number of religious conversions in Goa. "Our religious minority organisations are involved in helping the vulnerable sections of society. There is no evidence, nor have we heard that this has resulted in conversions."

The Goa Cabinet last week cleared the anti-conversion bill, proposing up to 14 years of imprisonment and outlawing conversion through force, coercion, undue influence, allurements, or marriage, among other punishments.

4 KILLED AS THAR OVERTURNS ON GANGA E-WAY

HAPUR: Four men were killed and a 17-year-old boy sustained injuries when a speeding Thar overturned on the Ganga Expressway in Uttar Pradesh's Hapur, police said on Monday. The accident occurred at 11.55 pm on Sunday when the SUV carrying five people from Budaun district was heading towards Delhi when it overturned five to six times before falling by the roadside, they said. They occupants were taken to the Sikhihda community health centre, where doctors declared four of them dead, police said. The deceased were identified as Joginder (26), Sukhbir (25), Jaswant (20) and Ravi (20), police said.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.



MAMATA SEEKS SWIFT EC DECISION ON TMC DISPUTE

Saubhadra Chatterji
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee has urged the Election Commission to expedite its inquiry into competing claims for recognition of the Trinamool Congress (TMC), alleging "irregularities" in Leader of the Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee's effort to reconstitute the party.

In a letter to the EC on Sunday, Mamata Banerjee cited claims by MLA Pirzada Kashem Siddique, who alleged that "no prior notice or communication was ever circulated to the members and stakeholders of the All India Trinamool Congress in respect of the purported 'Special Session' [called by the Ritabrata faction] of the AITC allegedly held on June 22, 2026, at Novotel Kolkata".

Mamata said the exercise conducted at Novotel Kolkata on June 22, 2026, was "vitiated by fundamental irregularities" and should not be treated as valid in the eyes of the law.

Bihar, J'khand ink pact to share Sone waters

Pallavi Singh
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Twenty-six years after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar, birthing an over two decade long water dispute, the two states signed an agreement Monday formalising the sharing of Sone river waters. The agreement allocates 5.75 million acre-feet (MAF) of Sone water to Bihar and 2 MAF to Jharkhand, from the 7.75 MAF originally allocated to the erstwhile undivided Bihar.

The MoU, as per a government release, was signed in the presence of Union home minister Amit Shah, Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren, Bihar chief minister Samrat Choudhary and Union ja shakti minister C R Patil.

HT had earlier reported that all details of the pact had been finalised and the chief ministers of both states would sign the pact on Monday.

The agreement settles the division of the erstwhile undivided Bihar's allocation under the 1973 Bansagar Agreement. The Bansagar Agreement, signed in 1973 between Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and the then undivided Bihar, governs the sharing of Sone river waters. While the agreement continued after Jharkhand was carved out in November 2000, the division of Bihar's share between the two successor states had remained unresolved for over 25 years.

The 5.75 MAF allocation to Bihar and 2 MAF to Jharkhand follows the unanimous recommendation of a committee constituted by the Centre under the chairmanship of the Central Water Commission to resolve the long-pending issue.

Shah said the agreement would ensure adequate water for drinking and irrigation across Bihar's Bhojpur, Buxar, Rohtas, Kaimur, Aurangabad, Arwal, Gaya and Patna districts. In Jharkhand, water would be available in Palamu, Garhwa and other regions, he said.

ASKED BY CERT-IN TO TONE DOWN POSTS, HACKER FLAGS NEW FLAW

NEW DELHI: Three days after nodal cybersecurity agency Cert-In asked a 19-year-old security researcher to tone down his social media posts about unresolved cyber vulnerabilities, the hacker demonstrated another potential security lapse by sending an email from an official gov.in account to Cert-In and other government recipients.

Nisarga Adhikary posted a screenshot on X on Monday showing an email sent from a 'gov.in' email account to Cert-In's incident reporting address. He wrote on X that he had found a vulnerability that allowed him to send emails from an official government account.

Adhikary told HT that after he demonstrated the vulnerability, the department took the affected subdomain offline, but its email service was hosted on a separate gov.in subdomain that remained accessible.

He claimed the same exploit continued to work against the email service.

SEJAL SHARMA

Pb yet to respond on new HC chief justice's appointment

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra's appointment as the full-time chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court appears to have run into a fresh hurdle, with the Aam Aadmi Party-led Punjab government yet to convey its views on the Supreme Court collegium's recommendation to the Centre more than a fortnight after it was forwarded to the state.

People aware of the matter said that the Union law ministry had sent the collegium's recommendation to the Punjab government for its comments, but the state was yet to respond.

One of the persons cited above told Hindustan Times that the Bhagwant Mann government was understood to be "still gathering relevant inputs" on Justice Mishra and would share its views with the Centre after the exercise was completed.

The delay assumes significance as the recommendation now finds itself at the intersection of the judicial appointment process and a potentially sensitive political dynamic, with Punjab governed by the AAP while the Union government is led by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

The Supreme Court collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and comprising Justices Vikram Nath and BV Nagarathna, had on August 6 recommended Justice Mishra's appointment as the full-time chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, along with three other full-time chiefs for the Bombay, Calcutta and Patna

high courts.

Justice Mishra has been functioning as the acting chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court since June 2, following the elevation of his predecessor, Justice Sheel Nagu, to the SC.

The collegium's recommendation had itself triggered questions from former Delhi CM and AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal, who on August 9 questioned the elevation of Justice Mishra, alleging that his appointment involved "bypassing seniority". "It seems there is a tearing hurry to go to SC. Should judges be allowed SC elevation out of turn, bypassing seniority? That makes him vulnerable to quid pro quo," Kejriwal said in a social media post.

Kejriwal's public questioning of the recommendation came hours after the collegium's recommendation was released and with Punjab yet to send its views, the appointment seems to have acquired an additional layer of scrutiny, and, potentially, a political dimension.

META ACTS AFTER GOVT FLAGS ADS FOR PORN APPS THAT HIJACK PHONE

NEW DELHI: Malicious android applications masquerading as pornography apps are increasingly being used by cybercriminals to take control of users' mobile phones and carry out unauthorised financial transactions, the Union home ministry's Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) warned.

The National Cybercrime Threat Analytics Unit (NCTAU), under I4C, said it observed a rise in financial frauds involving such applications, which are primarily promoted through advertisements on social media platforms.

The advisory was issued on August 26.

Meanwhile, Reuters reported that Meta on Monday removed dozens of advertisements after India flagged a pattern of Facebook and Instagram ads using sexually explicit content to lure users into downloading malware that could steal banking credentials and drain bank accounts.

HTC

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.



FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

{ OUR TAKE }

Decoding 7.8% GDP growth

Indian economy did well in the fog of war; it can do better by unlocking extra growth drivers

The National Statistics Office (NSO) released GDP data for the quarter ending June 2026 on Monday. This is the period when the oil shock on account of the ongoing war in West Asia was the worst. Everyone expected growth to slow down in India. Slow down it did; from 8.6% in the quarter ending March 2026, but it is still a bumper 7.8%. How should one read the latest GDP numbers? Three key messages could be drawn.

First, the most obvious and important fact. It is unambiguously good news for the Indian economy and underlines its resilience as far as facing temporary disruptions is concerned. The strong growth performance is rooted in private consumption demand, which is still enjoying multiple tailwinds such as GST and income tax relief announced last year, robust corporate profit momentum thanks to strong private demand, and most importantly, capable government intervention preventing a large supply crunch of petroleum products.

Having said that, it is still important that the West Asia war and its economic disruption end soon. If it does not end soon, the economic consequences will be more severe than what the June quarter numbers indicate.

Two, the inflationary implications of war seem to have delivered a double whammy for the fiscal situation. GDP growth in the June quarter is lower than its Gross Value Added (GVA) counterpart by 40 basis points. One basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point. GDP is GVA plus net indirect taxes, and the former lagging the latter in growth entails a higher subsidy burden. This is obvious given the limited pass-through of higher fuel and fertiliser prices to consumers. The nominal GDP growth, however, is only 10.3%, which is not very high by historical standards. This rules out any windfall in tax collections. Taxes are a fraction of nominal incomes. The war will definitely have a bearing on fiscal deficit, but not something which will be a severe disruption.

Three, the latest GDP numbers should not be allowed to mutate policy confidence into complacency. Some of the favourable cyclical tailwinds such as tax-cut induced demand boost will weaken going forward. A deficient monsoon will generate a drag on farm incomes. MPC's latest minutes suggest a growing concern about inflation in the economy. All this, put together, will weigh on future growth. This is why it is important that India unlocks the more difficult growth drivers via manufacturing and exports.

Growing dangers in the Himalayas

In 2023, the South Lhonak glacier disaster in Sikkim, forced India to build a systematic response to Himalayan cryospheric hazards. Some 195 high-altitude lakes across six Himalayan states and Union Territories are now identified and classified by vulnerability, with some level of monthly monitoring in place. This monitoring has centred on glacial lakes — high-altitude water bodies dammed by natural ridges of rock and debris left by retreating glaciers. The August 26 flash flood in Nepal, though, has now brought to the fore a mechanically different threat altogether: hanging glaciers, a mountain-side mass of ice, perched on a slope, collapsing and triggering catastrophic floods.

Research in the months before the Nepal flood found exactly this class of failure. It mapped 219 hanging glaciers in Uttarakhand's Alaknanda basin alone; its simulations projected flow heights of 40 to 51 metres at Badrinath and Hanuman Chatti. The risk of hanging glaciers' collapse is increasing. Another study on the Nepali catchment, immediately south of the Rasuwa collapse, found that warming rate of glacierised areas above 4,000 metres is five times the global average. The dangers in the Himalayas are expanding at both ends: more ice is at risk of failure, and this risk is travelling up.

The response must now widen along two axes at once. Hazard identification has to move beyond lakes to systematically inventory hanging-glacier and slope-instability risk across the Indian Himalayan arc. And mitigation has to account for events that current techniques such as reducing the volume of water in glacial lakes cannot prevent. Early-warning capacity and evacuation infrastructure, not only source-side intervention, may not be imperative. Activists and experts have already flagged construction, settlement expansion and pilgrim throughput in high-risk zones as unsustainable. The recent tragedies force a harder look at what we have made of the Himalayas.

OPINION The case for a climate risk budget for India

We need to be ready for the fiscal impact of monsoon extremes and plan ahead every time

This year's southwest monsoon has been a monsoon of contrasts. It has been uneven across time and space, weak in many districts, and extreme in short bursts elsewhere. June ended with all-India rainfall at 40% below normal. A few intense spells in July and August narrowed the seasonal deficit sharply. But by late August, all-India rainfall was still about 14% below normal.

That all-India figure masks much sharper regional deficits. In fact, states such as Bihar and Andhra Pradesh are facing deficits of around 40%. This means that large parts of India can remain rain-deficient even when a few regions receive extreme rain. A seasonal deficit and a local flood can happen in the same monsoon, even in the same week.

A super El Niño is evolving rapidly and could become the strongest we have recorded, adding further to this risk. An El Niño generally weakens the monsoon winds and increases the chance of below-normal rainfall. However, a weak monsoon does not mean weak weather risk. In a warming climate, the atmosphere and oceans carry more heat and moisture. When conditions become favourable, this moisture is often released as intense rain over a short period.

Over the Western Ghats, some locations received more than 1,000 mm of rain in just two days. Umargam in Gujarat recorded 1,064 mm in 24 hours, the third-highest daily rainfall ever recorded in India. To put this in perspective, 1,000 mm of rain means 1,000 litres of water falling on every square metre. On a 100 m² roof, that is about 100,000 litres, or 10 large water tankers. If drains are blocked, wetlands are lost, slopes are cut or floodplains are occupied, extreme rain can quickly turn into floods and landslides.

While the extreme rainfall we are witnessing is linked to global warming driven by increased greenhouse gas emissions, the destruction that follows are often shaped by what we do locally. Land-use change, hill-cutting, wetland loss, floodplain encroachment, and infrastructure built without proper environmental and climate assessment convert heavy rain into physical and economic damage. The climate crisis loads the system with hazards, but policy decisions how much of that rain becomes a disaster.

India must build infrastructure with the future climate in mind. Expressways, airports, ports, hill roads, bridges, tunnels, drainage systems, reservoirs, schools and hospitals are built to last several decades. They should not be designed solely on past

rainfall records and flood lines. Data on increasing extreme rainfall and future projections must inform their design, approval, and financing.

The agriculture and water risks are equally serious. Paddy, pulses, cotton, soybean, maize and oilseeds are sensitive to rainfall timing and distribution. By the end of June, kharif sowing was about 25% below last year because of delayed rains. July rainfall allowed farmers to catch up substantially, but newly planted cotton, soybean, maize and pulses remain vulnerable to another prolonged dry spell.

There is a positive side though. Forecasts, district crop advisories, reservoir monitoring and contingency plans have improved. Farmers in rain-fed regions can be advised to shift to short-duration and less water-intensive crops. States can repair ponds, check-dams, and water-harvesting structures before the season worsens. Local governments can desilt drains before intense rain arrives. But these should not remain stop-gap responses to emergency situations. They should be built into the way India budgets.

India needs a climate risk budget. Much of India's adaptation will be decided through ordinary public budgets, through how governments spend on agriculture, water, health, roads, housing, energy, schools, drainage and disaster management. The transforma-



The devastating flood in Nepal holds lessons for India in how a climate disaster becomes a fiscal disaster.

tion that we need is from climate finance to public budgeting, and from post-disaster spending to pre-disaster fiscal planning. India already spends on relief, compensation, reconstruction, crop losses and damaged infrastructure. This is necessary, but not enough. If the same disasters repeatedly flood heatwaves, floods, droughts, landslides, lightning, water stress or crop losses, prevention should be funded before losses occur.

UN secretary-general António Guterres recently called for better preparation before disasters strike and for pre-arranged finance to become the norm rather than the exception. He warned that climate disasters should not become fiscal disasters. The recent Nepal-Tibet disaster shows how quickly this can happen. After a catastrophic flood destroyed roads, bridges and power projects, Nepal has estimated reconstruction costs of \$4.5 billion. That warning applies directly to India.

The 10th Finance Commission has already moved in this direction. For 2026-31, it has recommended ₹2 lakh crore for State Disaster Response and Mitigation Funds, including ₹40,880 crore for mitigation. Importantly, 30% of state allocations are based on a Disaster Risk Index combining hazard, exposure and vulnerability, and preparedness and capacity-

building are explicitly treated as pre-disaster activities under mitigation. A climate risk budget should extend this logic beyond disaster funds into mainstream public investment.

A climate risk budget should have the following simple parts. First, every Union and state budget should include a climate risk statement identifying the main district-level risks for the year. Second, major public investments should be linked to spending and accountability. India should not wait for every weak monsoon, major flood or landslide or severe heatwave to become an emergency before finding money. We should budget the risk before we pay for the loss. As we do with our lives, families and homes, we need to insure the economy.

Roxy Mathew Koll is a climate scientist at the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology and a lead author of recent IPCC reports. Arunabha Ghosh is former CEO, Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), and co-author of Water, Nature, Progress: Solutions for a New India (HarperCollins). The views expressed are personal.

India needs a new deterrence doctrine

The 51st anniversary of the bombing of Hiroshima passed on August 6 without many in India noticing. But Indians should be particularly concerned, and not just because the use of nuclear weapons has been threatened (implicitly, if not explicitly) one too many times in recent years. More importantly, the world today seems to tolerate the aggregate toll from ongoing wars, which could parallel the death and destruction from a nuclear attack.

Data on civilian casualties are mysteriously unavailable, and every theatre of war is seeing the use of conventional missiles. Suddenly, it is no longer clear where red lines lie for nuclear powers. This raises important questions about what constitutes deterrence for India in security against two almost entirely different threats.

Let's first talk about the mounting casualties. The Hiroshima bomb killed some 333,639 people. In Ukraine, British intelligence indicates some 500,000 Russian soldiers have died since 2022, while Kyiv claims some 1.4 million were killed. Ukraine's own casualty data, however, remains classified, as does Russia's. Curiously, the West doesn't provide firm data on Russian civilians killed, though an analysis by the American think-tank, Center for Strategic and International Studies pegs total Russian deaths in the ongoing war as being times greater than all Soviet/Russian fatalities in all wars combined since World War II. That may just be point-scoring; after all, no such data on US casualties in the war against Iran or damage to US infrastructure is provided. On the other hand, there are claims of 36,000 people killed by the Iranian regime in just two days, during the January 6-8 crackdown on protests. Nobody seems to have the total casualty count for the Gulf countries. Therefore, aggregates and reports are selective, and the complete ignoring of civilian casualties is dangerous. It prevents a clear assessment by those whose business it is to work out strategy. The bottom line is clear, though. The Hiroshima toll was crossed long ago. And in these wars, one or the other party remains a nuclear power.

Witness, in Cold War language, was always seen through a nuclear prism in terms of an assurance of destruction given to an aggressor that would far outweigh the latter's gains in a war. For decades, it prevented war between superpowers, though low-level conflict continued, mostly in third countries. This principle has, more or less, got eroded now. Russia, with its massive nuclear pile, could not prevent Moscow and Leningrad from being attacked by Ukraine. Putin has repeatedly threatened nuclear strikes and conducted a revision of the Russian doctrine on nuclear use, which now allows targeting non-nuclear states if they have a nuclear capability. The key red line in the new doctrine is that nuclear use can only be activated when "a critical threat to their sovereignty and (or) territorial integrity" is involved. In other

words, anything short of that is permissible for an aggressor against Russia. So the country bleeds daily, with attacks on infrastructure and economy — exactly the kind of war the West wants. So, the first lesson in today's context is: A country's nuclear weapons are useless when the enemy perceives that an act of aggression or containment measures are in the offing, according to what the world perceives. For India, that is a valuable lesson. The question is how would New Delhi react to a conventional missile attack on a border city like Amritsar. One city is missile. What then?

The brilliance of India's Operation Sindoor came from its brevity and limited nuclear capability that sponsorship of terrorism has costs. The question then arises: Is Islamabad willing to risk another such operation? Apparently, yes. In an important shift, Islamabad binned off conventional missiles out of its nuclear arsenal, with a new Army Rocket Force Command — this leaves it free to use long range missiles without risk, circumventing the earlier problem that since New Delhi had no way of knowing whether a missile carried a conventional or nuclear warhead, instant and devastating retaliation was certain. Holes are also being plugged with precision missiles such as Fateh 2, a 600-km anti-ship Tamoor missile, and some six satellite launchers over 16,000 km, according to the Talshah Institute. India is responding similarly, including with a whopping \$2-billion earmarked for a panoply of drone and counter-drone systems. Both Pakistan and India's nuclear command-and-control systems are being upgraded with the tri-services — but only one country's is under political control. Rawalpindi clearly controls everything, including Pakistan's Prime Minister. India has proposed an Integrated Rocket Force, with nuclear Pralay as a clear candidate for the arsenal and others such as Brahmos also considered. It's expensive business, since entire systems would have to be duplicated to avoid co-location with nuclear assets. Each service will want its own missiles, but the use of even one short-range missile will need political acquiescence. It is just far too risky. In optical for this, however, India loses strategic ambiguity, particularly with regard to China, which co-locates its nuclear and conventional missiles.

The question is whether that is a good idea for either battlefield. Stand-off, high-tech capability is good for a range of warfare options, but it certainly erodes those red lines. How many deaths and number of cities hit constitute victory? That is a vital question for the political leadership. Public perception also matters, and any "off ramp" needs to consider that.

All in all, it seems that a new doctrine is needed to decide on such issues, that blends with the existing nuclear doctrine crafted by the brilliant K Subrahmanyam. But among other things, that earlier steel separation between conventional and nuclear use might have to be rethought. A Pralay is clearly conventional, but its range of 500 km means it can hit Pakistani cities or air bases, and vice versa with Pakistan's Abdhali. That's a strategic conventional option. Esoteric nuclear debates don't take this reality into account. It is time to think about deterring destruction as a whole, with clearly marked red lines that apply to both conventional and nuclear fields. The alternative is just too alarming.

Tara Kishor is a former director, National Security Council Secretariat. The views expressed are personal.

{ AMINA MOHAMMED } DEPUTY SECRETARY-GENERAL, UNITED NATIONS

We do already know that a warming climate is changing the world's ice at extraordinary speeds, not only threatening the communities below glaciers but adding more water to our oceans

Where arrival feels much like belonging

I have only been a few weeks since I arrived in New Delhi to begin my work as the UAE's ambassador to India. A moment such as this usually calls for a description of arriving in a new country and starting afresh. I would use a different word altogether. I would call it *apnapan* (belonging).

This is one of the first Hindi words I have learnt, and I understand that no single translation captures it neatly, yet I have understood it instinctively. From childhood I have lived among and developed close friendships with Indians in the UAE. Now I have the privilege of getting to know the landscapes and communities they speak so fondly about.

That affection runs both ways. The Indians that reside in the UAE are an essential part of Emirati life and have made our country their *karmahoomi*, and more importantly, their home. When a family sends one of its own across the seas, it entrusts another country with something precious. In Arabic, we call that an *amanah*. In Hindi, we say *amanat*. The words are almost identical because the feeling behind them is the same. We understand that responsibility. It rests on something that is both ancient and enduring.

On an island off Abu Dhabi, archaeologists have found pottery that travelled from the Indus Valley some 4,000 years ago. Until 1966, we bought and sold in rupees printed in India. Today, in Abu Dhabi, a Hindu temple stands in pink sandstone carved in Rajasthan and carries across the sea. Every Diwali, *diyas* line the balconies in Karama and Bur Dubai as they line streets across India. And on the night of August 15, the Bury Khalifa, the tallest building in the world, is lit up in the colours of the Indian flag.

These centuries of interactions are what our leaders carry forward to the present day. The deep respect shown between Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, President of the UAE, and Narendra Modi, Prime Minister of India, has made this relationship a strategic one, and as ambassador, my aim is to let its strength to inspire progress people can feel in everyday life.

The UAE-India Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) has carried trade between us past \$100 billion and held it there two years running. But the number

matters only for what it delivers in practice. Easier trade means a Keralan spice exporter reaching buyers in Dubai she could never have reached before. It means a tech founder in Bengaluru turning a company into a company in Abu Dhabi in weeks, not years, on the strength of trust over two countries' investors and institutions have built together.

It is essential that both our peoples rise together. That is the vision behind every agreement we sign and every investment we make. Education shows the ambition most plainly. IIT Delhi now teaches in Abu Dhabi. IIM Ahmedabad has opened in Dubai. A student who once had to choose between India and the UAE can now have both: an Indian degree earned on Emirati soil, and a first job at a company that spans the two. These are not gestures; they are open doors, and a generation is already walking through them.

India has inspired the world with its remarkable achievements, from building digital public services that reach hundreds of millions of people to expanding affordable health care and nurturing a vibrant spirit of entrepreneurship.

The UAE intends to be a partner in that progress. What our two countries can achieve with their respective strengths is already considerable. But considerable is just a beginning, not a ceiling, and beginnings like this reward patience. I spent nearly ten years as the UAE's ambassador to South Korea, long enough to watch trust compound into trade, and acquaintance into genuine friendship. I mean to give India that same patient depth.

While I have visited India several times before, living here is an opportunity to understand this country more deeply. My travels will take me well beyond Delhi. If you see me in your town, please tell me about your loved ones in the UAE. Tell me what you hope for them. From your vision for this partnership to the cricket team I should support and local dishes I should try, I want to hear all of it.

I may have arrived in India only recently. But thanks to the millions of Indians who have long made the UAE their home, this already feels a little like coming home, too.

Abdulla Saif Al Nuaimi is ambassador of the UAE to India. The views expressed are personal.

US, Iran trade fire for first time in a month

Reuters & Associated Press
DUBAI/NORTH CAROLINA: US President Donald Trump on Monday promised further strikes against Iran after the first tit-for-tat attacks in a month, as a conflict that had lately settled into an economic standoff threatened to escalate into open fighting again.

Iran launched missiles overnight at two US air bases in Jordan in response to a US attack on Iran's Larak Island, where Washington said it had struck Iranian launchers firing missiles into the Strait of Hormuz.

"We're going to hit them hard," a Fox News reporter quoted Trump as later telling the channel. "There will be a response."

A senior Iranian source told Reuters the overnight exchanges of fire, the first since late July, were a "limited and contained confrontation" but said Tehran would deliver a harsh response if attacked again.

Trump said US air defences had downed all Iranian missiles that could have caused any damage and that new US economic sanctions on Iran were having a big impact. Fox News reported.

UAE says it intercepted Iranian drone

In a short statement, the UAE defence ministry said it "dealt with" an Iranian drone that was detected over its waters approaching from Iran. There were no reports of damage.

The incident occurred after the US and Iran exchanged fire over the weekend.

This dangerous escalation constitutes a blatant violation of the UAE's sovereignty, security, and stability, and a direct threat to the safety of its citizens and residents," the foreign ministry said.

The defence ministry later issued a second statement denying a claim by the Iranian army that the Al Minhad Air Base in Dubai had been targeted, saying it was false.



Projectiles streak across the sky in footage published by Iranian authorities purporting to show missiles launched at US military targets in Jordan from an unknown location, on Monday.

Trump posts AI videos on Kharg island attack

Earlier, Trump had posted to social media two videos depicting explosions engulfing Iran's main oil export terminal, with the message "Kharg island being blown to smithereens!" But the videos were generated by AI and no such attack took place. Iran called Trump's post "laughable". Vice President JD Vance told reporters Trump "likes to switch it up on social media a little bit" and was "sending a message".

Washington has so far mainly held off from hitting Iran's major oil and gas infrastructure, a move that Iran says would be met with devastating attacks against its Gulf neighbours.

Since late July, the war that Trump launched with Israel six months ago has settled mostly into an economic standoff, with each side betting that rival blockades of shipping around the Gulf will force the other to back down.

Washington has recently stepped up efforts to punish Tehran and its business partners with "secondary sanctions" that hit third countries buying its oil.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Monday that Iran was "lashing out" now because the new sanctions were taking a toll on its already battered economy.

Stocks fall as US-Iran fighting sparks rally in oil

Stocks fell on Monday as oil prices jumped with a resumption of military clashes between the US and Iran adding to worries about inflation. US crude rose 2.54¢ to \$85.51 a barrel and Brent climbed to \$90.34 per barrel, up 2.54% on the day.

On Wall Street, the Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 356.59 points, or 0.67%, to 53,203.40, the S&P 500 fell 37.75 points, or 0.49%, to 7,674.22 and the Nasdaq Composite fell 103.71 points, or 0.39%, to 26,298.72.

The pan-European STOXX 600 was down 0.6% at 651.1 points on the day, with trading volumes subdued as London markets were closed for a bank holiday. MSCI's gauge of stocks across the globe fell 5.01 points, or 0.43%, to 1,148.15.

'No jurisdiction': India rejects Hague court's Indus Waters Treaty order

Rezaul H Laskar
letters@hindustantimes.com
NEW DELHI: India on Monday rejected the Permanent Court of Arbitration's order setting aside its decision to suspend the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) with Pakistan, saying it had never recognised the existence of the "illegally-constituted" court in The Hague.

The Indian government also rejected the Permanent Court of Arbitration's order on interim measures prohibiting New Delhi from building certain structures of the Ratle hydroelectric project in Jammu and Kashmir.

"India's decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance remains in force," the external affairs ministry said.

India held the IWT in abeyance as part of a package of punitive diplomatic and economic measures unveiled in April 2025 in response to the Pafalgam terror attack, carried out by a proxy for

the terms of the treaty and India categorically rejects its so-called award, just as it has firmly rejected all prior pronouncements by this illegally constituted body.

India has "never recognised the existence in law of this illegally-constituted and so-called Court of Arbitration", and has always said the "very establishment of this alleged arbitral body constitutes a grave violation of the Indus Waters Treaty", according to the statement.

The Court of Arbitration has "no jurisdiction whatsoever to pronounce on India's sovereign decisions" and its "pronouncements, now or in the future, will have no effect on India's actions in connection with the projects being undertaken by India".

Since it suspended the treaty, the Indian side has stepped up work on several hydropower projects in Jammu and Kashmir that Pakistan had opposed under the provisions of the pact signed in

1960. Among these are the Ratle and Kishenganga hydropower projects, over which Pakistan had sought the formation of a court of arbitration.

The Permanent Court of Arbitration said in a press release that the court considered the meaning of India's decision to suspend the treaty, "finding that it could only be a claim that the Indus Waters Treaty is either suspended or terminated".

The court examined the potential grounds on which India can suspend or terminate the treaty, including grounds cited by New Delhi in its public statements. "In a unanimous decision, the court found that none of these grounds could justify suspension or termination of the treaty. Accordingly, the Indus Waters Treaty remains fully in force, and India must observe its obligations under the treaty, including those relating to the design and operation of its hydro-electric projects on the Western Rivers," the release said.

the terms of the treaty and India categorically rejects its so-called award, just as it has firmly rejected all prior pronouncements by this illegally constituted body.

the terms of the treaty and India categorically rejects its so-called award, just as it has firmly rejected all prior pronouncements by this illegally constituted body.

the terms of the treaty and India categorically rejects its so-called award, just as it has firmly rejected all prior pronouncements by this illegally constituted body.

PAK: MORE MUSLIM NATIONS KEEN TO JOIN DEFENCE PACT

ISTANBUL: Pakistan said six to seven Muslim-majority countries are interested in joining the Mecca Defence Agreement, as top diplomats from Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkey met in Istanbul on Monday to discuss security cooperation.

Pakistan, Saudi and Turkish officials are working on an agreement framework to make it easier for other countries to join. Pakistan's foreign minister Ishaq Dar said.

Bangladesh is the latest country to express interest in joining the pact, signed on August 7, which stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three nations will be considered an attack on them all. The alliance was established with the intention of expansion," Turkish foreign minister Hakan Fidan said at a press conference following the meeting.

RSS chief extols virtue of 'unity in diversity' in his Canada address

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
letters@hindustantimes.com
TORONTO: Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat extolled the virtue of "unity in diversity" while addressing a large gathering in Canada's Greater Toronto Area on Sunday evening. This was RSS sarsangchalak's first-ever visit to Canada and he addressed a gathering of over 2,000 community members. The event was organised by the Canadian Hindus for Outreach, Relations and Dialogue (CHORD).

Joining Bhagwat on the stage were the former premier of Alberta province, and former Canadian cabinet minister, Jason Kenney, and Kashmiri Singh Dhalwal, representing the Vancouver-headquartered Khalsa Diwan Society, which manages the com-



Mohan Bhagwat

try's historic Ross Street gurdwara. "Diversity is never a problem for unity, because our tradition tells us not only of unity in diversity, but of diversities of unity." He saw diversity as an "expression of unity".

Expanding on the theme, Bhagwat said, "We have to serve, accept, respect this diversity because it is an expression of unity, it beautifies it, it is the decora-

Khalistan extremist blames Goldy Brar for Nijjar killing
TORONTO: An unveiled audio has leaked of prominent pro-Khalistan separatist Paramjit Singh Pamma blaming gangster Goldy Brar for the killing of Hardeep Singh Nijjar on June 18, 2023.

Pamma is heard saying in the message to Brar, "By killing a respected person like Hardeep Singh Nijjar, you and your gang have signed your own death warrants."

Japan seeking record \$55.6bn defence budget
TOKYO: Japan's defence ministry requested a record budget of \$55.6 billion on Monday as Tokyo looks to artificial intelligence to speed up decision-making in the face of a tense security environment. Tokyo is undertaking a sweeping upgrade of its defence in order to navigate growing tension with China, North Korea and Russia.

US military has no plans to deploy for midterm polls
WASHINGTON: The highest-ranking officer in the US military says there are no plans to send troops to polling places during November's midterm congressional elections, addressing concerns among Democrats that the Trump administration could use the military to interfere with the vote. Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, made the statement in a letter to Michigan Democratic Sen. Elissa Slotkin.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



READ EVERY SUNDAY



NCLT sets up bigger bench for hearing Chandra case

Krishna Yadav
krishna.yadav@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: Hours after an appeals court agreed to hear aggrieved lenders in the Subhash Chandra case, the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) formed a new five-member special bench to reconsider the Special Bench's decision on the Group's former's repayment plan. The Delhi bench of NCLT said its previous three-member bench which heard the plan could not agree on how it would operate.

The five-member bench of NCLT president Justice Anupinder Singh Grewal, judicial members Bachu Venkat Balaram Das and Mahendra Khandewal Das, and technical members Atul Chaturvedi and Ravindra Chaturvedi, will hear the matter on Tuesday.

The case concerns Chandra's liability as a personal guarantor for loans taken by several Essel and Zee-linked companies.

Earlier on Monday, creditors LIC, Housing Finance, HDFC Bank and Union Bank of India



A file photo of Subhash Chandra.

had moved an urgent petition before the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) against NCLT's Friday ruling.

The NCLT clarified that there was no majority view on Chandra's repayment plan. One member had favoured applying the repayment plan only to creditors who supported it.

While allowing dissenting banks and financial institutions to pursue separate recovery proceedings, another member held that the plan should apply to all creditors, including those who opposed it.

The tribunal said the two views had different consequences for the rights of dissenting creditors.

"All said and done, no majority view has emerged in the matter. In the wake, no order can be passed at this stage. Resultantly, we have no option but to make fresh reference to Hon'ble President in terms of the provisions of Section 41(5) of the Code," the NCLT said.

The latest twist comes days after the third member had approved Chandra's repayment plan under which he would pay ₹6.5 crore. Of this, ₹6.25 crore would go towards creditors, while ₹25 lakh would be used to meet insolvency process costs.

The original claims in the case was about ₹2,00,05.57 crore. Mint first reported that Nitesh Sharma, who was included as the third member by the NCLT president in February 2026, had approved the repayment plan on 25 August. The plan ran into opposition, with HDFC Bank, Axis Bank, Canara Bank, RBL Bank and Union Bank of India voting against it. However, the plan received 80.83% support from creditors by value.

APR-JULY FISCAL DEFICIT 26.8% OF FY28 TARGET

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: India's fiscal deficit stood at ₹4.55 lakh crore or 26.8% of the full-year budget estimate at the end of July, according to the latest monthly accounts released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) on Monday.

The deficit was 29.9% of the annual target in the corresponding period of the previous year. The deficit rose to 26.8% of the annual target by July from 18.2% at the end of June, as government expenditure continued to exceed receipts. The Centre has budgeted a fiscal deficit of ₹16.96 lakh crore, or 4.3% of GDP, for FY27. It is counting on robust tax collections and higher non-tax revenues in the coming months to meet this target.

The fiscal deficit is the gap between the government's total expenditure and receipts, excluding borrowings. The latest data shows India's fiscal position remained under control in the opening months of FY27, even as spending—especially capital expenditure—picked up speed. Fiscal health was also bolstered by the rise in April-June 2026 of ₹1.57 billion in April-June 2026. Experts said fluctuations in 2026 imports are driven by the commercial considerations of oil and gas.

At the same time, imports of petroleum products, mainly light oil and propane, rose from about ₹735 billion in the first quarter of 2025-26 to ₹2.60 billion in the corresponding period this year.

Overall, India imported merchandise worth ₹16.65 billion in the first quarter of 2025-26 to ₹2.60 billion in the corresponding period of 2026-27, including crude oil and petroleum products, a nearly 24% increase from ₹13.44 billion in the same quarter of the previous financial year. India's merchandise exports to the US, however, were largely flat, slipping marginally to \$25.46 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27 from \$25.48 billion a year earlier, the data showed.

Experts and people familiar with the matter said India's overall exports have continued to show an upward trend, added by

LPG imports from US surge, oil buys fall in Q1

Rajeev Jayaswal
rajeev.jayaswal@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: India's imports of petroleum products from the US, mainly liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), surged 25.4% year-on-year to \$2.60 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27, even as crude oil imports from the country fell 57.5% to \$1.57 billion during the same period, according to government data.

The rise in LPG imports during April-June was partly driven by global energy supply disruptions, including the war in West Asia, particularly disruptions affecting supplies from the Gulf region, experts said, requesting anonymity. LPG, or cooking gas, is a variable mix of propane and butane. Oil marketing companies often import the two components separately in liquid form.

According to the latest available granular data, India's crude oil imports from the US fell from \$3.70 billion in April-June 2025 to \$1.57 billion in April-June 2026. Experts said fluctuations in 2026 imports are driven by the commercial considerations of oil and gas.

At the same time, imports of petroleum products, mainly light oil and propane, rose from about ₹735 billion in the first quarter of 2025-26 to ₹2.60 billion in the corresponding period this year.

Overall, India imported merchandise worth ₹16.65 billion in the first quarter of 2025-26 to ₹2.60 billion in the corresponding period of 2026-27, including crude oil and petroleum products, a nearly 24% increase from ₹13.44 billion in the same quarter of the previous financial year. India's merchandise exports to the US, however, were largely flat, slipping marginally to \$25.46 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27 from \$25.48 billion a year earlier, the data showed.

Experts and people familiar with the matter said India's overall exports have continued to show an upward trend, added by



The rise in LPG imports was driven by global energy supply disruptions.

trade diversification, a country-specific approach and greater focus on individual products. They said there was considerable scope to expand both exports to and imports from the US.

The commerce ministry has convened a meeting of industry associations and export promotion councils on Tuesday to discuss ways to boost India's exports, including the country's trade performance with the US, they said.

India's cumulative merchandise exports in the first four months of the current financial year, April-July 2026, rose more than 17% to \$173.78 billion, and a similar double-digit annual growth rate is expected for August, according to people familiar with the matter.

They said the meeting was aimed at helping India achieve a record \$1 trillion in combined goods and services exports in the current financial year. India recorded exports of \$863 billion in 2025-26, comprising \$442 billion in merchandise and \$421 billion in services. The meeting also comes ahead of commerce minister Piyush Goyal's expected visit to the US for the G20 Trade Ministerial in Milwaukee, beginning September 30. The two countries' trade ministers may hold bilateral discussions on the sidelines of the two-day meeting, people familiar with the matter said.

AIRLINE PILOTS BODY RAISES TAILSTRIKES ON A321s WITH AAIB

Neha LM Tripathi
neha.tripathi@livemint.com

NEW DELHI: The Airline Pilots' Association of India (AIPI) has urged the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) to issue formal safety recommendations on tailstrike protection, simulator training and aircraft design, arguing that recurring incidents involving the Airbus A321 family point to a "systemic and institutional" problem rather than individual pilot error.

The pattern of recurrence demonstrates that the root cause of these events is systemic and institutional—not individual pilot failure," AIPI said in a letter to the AAIB dated August 31.

The pilots' body said the recent Gorakhpur incident where an IndiGo flight had a tailstrike event, was the seventh confirmed tailstrike involving an A321-family aircraft on the Indian civil register since 2020, and the second such incident at a tier-2 airport in 2026.

It said the aircraft was grounded and the crew de-registered pending an investigation.

People aware of the matter, however, said the aircraft had subsequently returned to operations after operating a ferry flight from Gorakhpur to Delhi last week. AIPI has asked the AAIB to issue safety recommendations to the civil aviation ministry and the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) covering A321NEO simulator training, at approved training organisations and set a six-month compliance timeline for procuring, or securing, contracted access to qualified full-flight simulators. AIPI said that "no Approved Training Organisation (ATO) in India has publicly confirmed availability of an A321NEO Full Flight Simulator (Level D) with validated NEO-specific Flare Law fidelity.

Govt cuts silicon fab support to 40% under Semicon 2.0

Sejal Sharma
sejal.sharma@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday reduced the support for silicon fabs from 50% to 40% while notifying the Semicon 2.0 scheme, with Union minister for IT and electronics Ashwini Vaishnaw calling the renewed support "globally competitive."

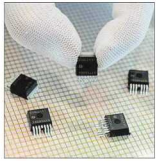
—neither extraordinarily low nor high. Under the 2022 scheme—Semicon 1.0—eligible silicon fabs could receive 50% of project cost. The second edition of the scheme now provides 40% support on an equivalent basis for eligible capital expenditure.

Speaking to media on Monday, Vaishnaw said lowering the

support won't be a disadvantage to the industry as it is moving at a fast pace, and several factors like ease of doing business and India's policy certainty added to the government's decision making.

"When we started Semicon 1.0 in 2022, the global semiconductor majors had serious doubts about India. That doubt is now replaced by confidence. They now believe India is the right place for making major investments in the coming decades," said Vaishnaw.

The new scheme, with a total outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore, approved by the Union Cabinet in July, has been divided into 10 categories of support and six pillars. The pillars include chip



The new scheme has a total outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore.

design, machines and materials, expanded semiconductor fabs, advanced packaging, research and development, and talent development. While support for silicon fabs

has come down, the government has created dedicated support for display fabs, covering OLED, Micro LED and LCD technologies. OLED and LCD projects require a minimum ₹1,000 crore investment and will get 35% support, while a Micro LED project requires a minimum ₹1,500 crore investment and also get 35% support.

Packaging is another addition. Semicon 2.0 provides 35% support for advanced packaging, including 2.5D and 3D packaging, wafer-level chip-scale packaging and heterogeneous integration. Legacy packaging projects will get 25% support.

The government is also widening support to the equipment

and materials that go into making chips. This includes semiconductor equipment, sub-assemblies and components, as well as wafers, photomasks, photoresists, substrates, chemicals, gases and other semiconductor-grade materials. Equipment manufacturers will also be eligible for a separate provision-linked incentive based on the value of components sourced from domestic manufacturers.

For commercial chip design, startups and MSMEs can receive seed funding of up to ₹15 crore, while equity co-investment will also be available. Larger eligible companies can access royalty financing or equity co-investment.

ADANI SHARES LOSE \$15 BN AS CLOSING AUCTION FUELS SWINGS

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Adani Group companies on Monday erased ₹1.4 lakh crore (\$15 billion) in market value, the most in about 21 months, as India's closing auction drove sharp swings during a scheduled MSCI Inc. index rebalancing.

Flagship Adani Enterprises Ltd. plunged 9.8% on Monday, its biggest one-day decline since January, while Adani Energy Solutions Ltd. sank more than 10%. All nine listed companies controlled by the ports-to-power conglomerate ended lower, with three firms slipping more than 6% each. Several companies saw heightened volatility during the end of auction as passive funds adjusted their holdings to align with the rebalancing of indices. The sharp swings underscored that despite managing to absorb almost \$4.2 billion in MSCI-related flows, the new end-of-day pricing mechanism continues to witness sharp moves, prompting some market participants to question its rollout.

Passive trackers were expected to channel about \$10 million into Adani Energy following its inclusion in the MSCI Standard Index, according to Nuvama Alternative & Quantitative Research.

Adani Enterprises and the ports unit were expected to attract \$202 million and \$77 million, respectively. "The sharp fall in the two Adani counters, despite passive buying, suggests that traders built positions that didn't meet expectations, possibly leading to forced liquidation," said Arun Kejriwal, founder of Kejriwal Research & Investment Services.

The selloff marked the Adani Group's biggest single-day drop in market value since November 2024, when US prosecutors charged billionaire Chairman Gautam Adani in connection with alleged bribery involving solar-energy contracts in India. Adani and the group companies repeatedly denied the allegations.

Earlier this month, the billionaire won dismissal of the US fraud probe, ending a legal overhang that had weighed on the conglomerate.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

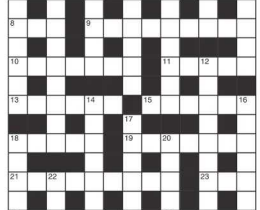
- ACROSS**
1. Apathy shown just after fifty (5)
 2. Where feathers used to fly (pilots still do it) (7)
 3. In brief this is another word for next (3)
 4. Meeting support I've carved in anyway (9)
 5. An inquiry into the cause of being late (7)
 6. Clubs in which offenders may have been found (5)
 7. Cured by drink he'd swallowed? (6)
 8. No notice is required should you wish to do it (6)
 9. Senior citizen upset Mary about nothing (5)
 10. Offers received by nurses without hesitation (7)
 11. Insulting attack (9)
 12. A problem in Arctic exploration (3)
 13. Reveals outdated attitudes (7)
 14. Not smiling back (5)

DOWN

1. Rubens for example put himself out (7)
2. He never added anything new to his collection (9)
3. Verbal criticism of the show (5)
4. King who upset his aunt in church (6)
5. People may take steps to paint it (7)
6. In shape and size one is very like another (7)
7. Checked garments for Scottish soldiers (5)
8. Reserved but singularly partisan (2,3,4)
9. One may have had them on them; darners renew them (7)
10. Oriental nets are cast differently (7)
11. Tips to change the rules of conduct (6)
12. Animal's low points (5)
13. Wants to see Eden's development (5)
14. Dandy loudly goes to work (3)

PUZZLE 17579

© Gemini Crosswords 2018 All rights reserved



QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
1. A venomous snake (5)
 2. A diabolical (7)
 3. A useful attribute (5)
 4. Close friend (5)
 5. Type of waterproof hat (9)
 6. Worked up (7)
 7. An enticement (5)
 8. Secretly follow and watch (6)
 9. To moderate (5)
 10. Sorely (5)
 11. Make a spectacular profit (5,2)
 12. Wide-bombed soft felt hat (7)
 13. In the past (5)
 14. Beat off (7)
 15. Dartsful trick (5)
- DOWN**
1. An evergreen tree (7)
 2. A useful attribute (5)
 3. A useful attribute (5)
 4. Strongly built (6)
 5. Foot-operated (7)
 6. Head-shedded dry fruit (3)
 7. Hot-tasting Indian dish (5)
 8. Humble (3,2,4)
 9. Viewed as a whole (7)
 10. Chide (7)
 11. An abrasion (5)
 12. Political control (5)
 13. Edit to remove errors (5)
 14. Brief battle in sea (3)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17578)



{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL: ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

ALMANAC
Today is 4th September 2026
1st of the month, 14th of the year, 14th of the century.
Sunset: Sunday
Moonset: Sunday
Moonrise: Sunday

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

City	Temp
Delhi	35°C / 95°F
Mumbai	32°C / 90°F
Kolkata	32°C / 90°F
Chennai	32°C / 90°F
Bangalore	29°C / 85°F

Messi closes the Argentina chapter



"I have nothing left to give," said football's talismanic figure as he signed off from internationals

Dhiman Sarkar
dhiman@htlive.com

KOLKATA: The first time he announced retirement from international football, it lasted less than three months.

If it feels way more real this time it is because between those torment-riddled days from June 27 to September 1 in 2016 and now, Lionel Messi has won everything football has to offer, played more than double the number of international matches Diego Maradona did, on way to equalling the achievements of the patron saint of Argentina men's football team.

He is also 39 and had before Monday's announcement at least twice hinted that the end was near. The first was before the 2026 World Cup final and then after his father Jorge died earlier this month when he said, "my legs couldn't go on anymore."

And yet it was not an easy decision, he said. Ending a saga that began against Hungary in 2005 — with a red card — not long after winning the world under-20 championship and had 207

matches for Argentina could not have been.

"It was a decision that hurt — and still hurts deep down — but I understand that the time has come," Messi said.

"Time is running short, chapters come to a close, and this is one that hurts me deeply. I love, have loved, and will always love being part of the national team. I've given everything I had; I have nothing left to give, and besides, there are some great young players coming up who deserve to be here."

After his father's death, Messi had said: "I don't know what I am going to do without you. I don't know how to go on." Argentina has five Nobel laureates and it is the country of the short story writer and polyglot Jorge Luis Borges.

But for the world at large, it is the men's football team Argentina are known for. Messi amplified what Maradona did in the 91 times he represented Argentina: get most of the world to love them.

If dropping Maradona's name released Argentine tourists from the clutches of Egyptian bandits, in Qatar head coach Lionel Scaloni thanked Bangladesh for backing Argentina.

So, when Messi's father died, the world mourned, a private grief triggered a public outpouring. But for Jorge putting his life on hold and taking his son to Barcelona, the world wouldn't have seen Lionel Messi.

Argentina acknowledged that and so did the rest of the world.

"You were by my side from the beginning; there was so little left until the end," Messi said. "I only played football and now I have quite a few doubts about whether I will keep doing it for much longer."

Messi has returned to playing for Inter Miami where he has a contract till 2028. That is also when the next Copa America is due but Messi has decided that at 41, he didn't want to be around when Argentina attempt a hat-trick of titles. Cristiano Ronaldo is 41 now and he has also said that 2026-27 would "probably" be his last year as a player. Between them, Messi and Ronaldo won every Ballon d'Or from 2008 to 2017 and in 2019, 2021 and 2023.

Ronaldo won his first international tournament before Messi and has more goals for his country (146 to Messi's 125) but the Argentine has since left him behind with a World Cup and two Copa America titles. Messi's World Cup legacy will take some beating.

No one has played as many finals matches (34) and only one player, Kylian Mbappe, has scored more World Cup goals than Messi's 12. His 33 goal contributions in the World Cup helped Argentina to three final appearances (only Cafu has that many).

Ten goal contributions (7 goals, three assists) came in the edition Argentina won to end a 36-year wait. In 15 games of the last two

editions of the World Cup that he played, Messi was adjudged player of the match in 10. He is the only player to have won the Golden Ball twice.

It ended with Argentina being outplayed by Spain; Messi touching the ball only 46 times. And a World Cup career that began with a misplaced pass against Serbia and Montenegro in 2006 finished with Messi going gently into the night.

That was the last the world saw Messi in an Argentina shirt. Sometimes, even the greatest do not get the ending they want. Doesn't matter. "He is pure history. A legend," Scaloni has said.

Messi's announcement came hours after Novak Djokovic lost in the US Open first round. The last time that happened was in the year Messi played his first World Cup. Djokovic hasn't yet spoken the r-word but men's tennis has new stars.

As Messi has said, Argentina's football team are not lacking in them either. Time to make way, time to end a journey as a captain that began in a friendly against Venezuela in Kolkata.

"Thank you for all the love over these 20 years. I'm going to miss hearing you all from the pitch so much. Now I'll be just one of you, always cheering you on and supporting you from the sidelines (through thick and thin — especially the tough times). ... Thank you, God, for making me Argentine. Vamos Argentina."

We will be grateful to you for the rest of our lives for taking Argentina to the top of the world. For choosing to represent Argentina when you could easily have chosen something else. Thank you, Captain.... The greatest in history

ANGEL DI MARIA, Ex-Argentina teammate

You are my example and an example for the whole world, a winner in football and a winner in life!! My daughter will be very proud that her father shared a team with such an extraordinary human being. You are the greatest athlete in history, I love you so much

LISANDRO MARTINEZ, teammate

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

Now, Sooryavanshi breaks a 57-yr-old Duleep Trophy record

That CWG, in 2030, should be India's first aim, for now.

"Indian swimmers have never worn a CWG medal. That would be like winning an Olympic gold to start with," said Kelly. "It would create an enormous amount of momentum, because millions of kids will see that and will inspire them, and they will have an idol."

